The Strangest House in Paris

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The Strangest House in Paris

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Summary

When Nathalie's condition gets worse she and Gabriel are forced to concede he needs a new administrative assistant to take the burden off her. All they have to do is act normal. That should be fine right?

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

When Claude had been mulling over whether to take the job everyone he'd spoken to had warned him about the man he'd be working for if he did.

Even the women in HR who'd offered him the job had seemed apologetic, and not just because it was only a temporary role.

However what they don't necessarily know, or apparently seem to remember in the case of his friends, are the absolutely mad things he's been expected to do before. When he'd started working he'd never have thought finding a Michelin-starred restaurant in Paris for a business lunch which would cater to a fruitarian would be one of the easier things he'd have to do but it turns out that the richer people are more detached from reality they become.

Whatever his actual job title it's his job to make sure their lives run so smoothly they don't even notice that abyss exists and that's included dealing with a lot of things he hadn't even known existed before.

All rich people are weird. Mostly in the same ways if you boil down to it. How bad can Gabriel Agreste be?

Sure the man basically never leaves his house but while it's makes things difficult for the rest of the company by the standard of rich eccentrics he's not even sure that signifies. Honestly it's almost a stereotype and frankly Claude is in favour of anything that reduces travel arrangements.

The only thing that sets Gabriel Agreste's particular flavour of weirdness apart from standard rich people weirdness is the missing wife but Claude prefers to leave the true crime podcasts to his girlfriend and ignore all the conspiracy theories there.

Besides, while it's nearly always the husband in Elodie's podcasts he'd actually seen Gabriel and Emilie Agreste together back when the founder of the company he worked for actually did venture into the outside world and M.Agreste certainly hadn't looked like a man considering murdering his wife. Quite the opposite in fact.

It's funny how when he'd been considering whether to take the role he'd barely given a thought to most of this and had been much more focused on the luck of *Gabriel* offering him another role at a higher salary after the retirement of the FD he'd been working directly below, and one that was a temporary placement so he'd be ready to move with Elodie when she took up her new job in Marseille later in the year.

It had seemed like the perfect job.

Some silly ideas sprouted by idiots with too much time on their hands had seemed like nothing in comparison.

Now standing in front of the mansion the rumours seem much louder.

Still he supposed it was time to stop hesitating and ring the buzzer.

A camera dropped down from the gate and a women's voice queried his identity,

He introduced himself and was told to come in. The gate opened automatically and he walked up to the front door which was opened before he had time to request entrance again.

"M. Berger, welcome to the Agreste Mansion. I'm Natalie Sancoeur, M.Agreste's current administrative assistant." a pale professionally dressed woman said proffering her hand.

He shook it. "Please Claude is fine"

Her lips pressed together clearly unimpressed. "M.Agreste prefers formality."

He wondered where the red streak in her hair fitted with formality but then he supposed they did technically work in a creative industry, and he'd seen much odder in the members of the company actually working in the design department.

"I see." He said, already feel wrong-footed, "I didn't mean to give offence."

"None taken. Right, you'd better come in then so I can give you the tour. We'll be working together over the next week. Hopefully that will be time enough to get you settled in."

He glanced round the lobby as he followed her further into the house.

It was very...white.

Despite working for *Gabriel* he'd never made much attention to the brand's output. Still he'd never had the impression the designer was as allergic to colour as this interior suggested.

Even the portrait of the designer and his son at the top of the stairs had them dressed in monochrome. Or mourning he supposed based on the expressions. Was hanging a funereal portrait without confirmation your wife was dead proof you knew she was?

Yet Emilie Agreste had been gone for over a year. He supposed that was enough to go through the various stages of grief and reach acceptance. After all the chances that she was alive after all this time seemed pretty non-existent.

People didn't just re-appear after that sort of time short of some Miracle.

Still the painting seems to hold his attention, as if he couldn't break away from it. He was sure serial killers were supposed to collect trophies, he might not really listen to those podcasts but that was definitely a thing, but he wasn't sure that this really qualified and besides it was only one person M.Agreste was suspected to have killed so it wasn't like he was a *serial* killer even if he *had* murdered his wife.

Which he hadn't.

Probably.

Anyway the man’s business *was* fashion. Being dramatic was practically part of the job description.

Unlike him Mlle. Sancoeur had kept walking clearly well-used to the strange atmosphere of the house.

"You'll be working in here. Mainly." She said opening a door off the hallway to an office. Well there was a desk, chair and computer at least if little else. Apparently the minimalism was consistent through the house.

He tried not to react to the smell of fresh paint permeating the room. “Mainly?”

“As you know M.Agreste prefers not to attend most events in person, you’ll need to be his representative out in the world, and while he does have a driver and bodyguard, the job includes a certain amount of supervision of M.Agreste’s son Adrien as well.”

“Yes, I’d heard.”

“Good. The next door along is the atelier. You should not enter this without ringing through first. In fact you probably won’t be able to as the door is usually kept locked. Both for proprietary reasons and because M.Agreste dislikes his creative process being interrupted.”

“I see.”

She must have noticed his discomfort and raised an eyebrow. “You’ll get used to it.”

“I’m sure.”

She brought him round wherever else in the house she deemed it worth him knowing; the kitchen, the dining room, Adrien’s frankly unreal bedroom, and then lead him back to the office to start explaining the actual job.

For the first time some level of emotion entered her voice as she tried to explain exactly what was upcoming soon, what needed to be done, who to put through automatically on the phone, who to stonewall and more as if she didn’t have a few days to ease him in.

Intermittently she’d break off coughing but she waved off his offer to get some water.

Still he wanted to offer her some reassurance, "Don't worry, your system will be just as you left it when you return."

To say she reacted might have been overstating it but there was the faintest widening of her eyes as she said. "Return?"

"Um, HR gave me the impression this was temporary cover while you took sick leave. Is that incorrect?"

What illness exactly Mlle. Sancoeur had hadn't been disclosed, but if it wasn't for the fact she honestly did not look well then the pause and glance towards the wall dividing them from

M.Agreste's atelier before she responded might have made him wonder if sick leave was a euphemism, and gardening leave might have been the better term.

"No, that's correct." She said.

When it reached Mlle. Sancoeur's last day Claude felt he had mostly gotten to grips with his new role. The last few days had been as normal as working in a set-up like this could be. Was wasn't much but *was* something he was capable of managing.

He understood why they'd recruited inside the company because having some idea of the brand's operations certainly helped. Still he could tell following Nathalie Sancoeur was going to be a hard act to live up to and that was allowing for the fact that he wasn't being expected to do everything she'd done. Some of it had been delegated with new instructions only to send it to M.Agreste when it was actually finished.

Other parts. He hadn't been told they'd been passed back up but looking at certain email trails and paperwork he had a suspicion she'd been taking on work M.Agreste should have done himself.

Not that he had much chance of confirming that since he had yet to speak to his boss in person rather than on the phone or the tablet but he couldn't say he regretted it.

Technically Claude had met him, if you consider knocking on a door and having some papers taken from you with no words of thanks meeting someone. Claude didn't.

Still those few interactions that only furthered his impression that if he got through this whole thing without meeting M.Agreste in person at all he'd be happy enough and he rather thought his new boss thought the same.

In fact Claude was starting to form a decided dislike for the other man. Not because he was abrupt and demanding-that wasn't news to him; but while the company had always taken care of Claude and his colleagues well its ethos clearly didn't stem from its namesake. The more time he spent with Mlle. Sancoeur the clearer it became that she should have stopped working before this.

Beside the coughing and how she often clung to the table as she stood up or sat down she also seemed exhausted. He'd come back from lunch one day and found her asleep collapsed forward on her desk.

If she'd worked back in the company offices with other people around there was no way she'd have been allowed to have continued working this long. Here the only other person around was M. Agreste himself, who clearly didn't care enough to do anything.

He'd vented to Elodie about it over dinner the other night and she'd pointed out that from his description of his working conditions saying the two of them worked together sounded like a bit of stretch.

However given how much they were in contact, including video calls, it was hard to believe nothing had been noticed, and if Gabriel Agreste had been somewhat aware his assistant wasn't well and never followed up on it that wasn't really that much better than if he'd let her continue working knowing how bad she was.

He glanced over at her desk which had gone oddly quiet in the last minute or so. She was frowning at a stapled pile of paper. Either she felt his gaze on her or she was going to speak anyway because she looked up at him and said "This needs signing off and returning today."

"Ah." He acknowledged but she made no motion to rise. He wondered at her hesitancy at what should have been a routine part of her job. Their boss was abrupt but she must be used to that "Do you want me to take it in to him?"

She set the papers back down on her desk, and seemed to consider his suggestion, but she sighed and went "It's probably better I do it in case he has any questions, but if you could run it out to the post afterwards that would be great."

Having made her decision she headed for the door of the Atelier and knocked confidently without any sign of her earlier hesitance. M.Agreste looked irritated when he opened the door but silently waved her in and shut the door behind her.

Which was odd now Claude thought about it.

His expression hadn't looked any different to whenever Claude had brought anything to him to action, but while Nathalie had told him to let M.Agreste know if anything important or urgent was there, she hadn't said anything and he'd automatically invited her in.

It could have been that he recognised the documents she'd brought over and did have questions for her on them. Certainly it wouldn't be unlike the man not to waste any words vocalising any of that, but there barely seemed to have been time for him to notice what she was holding, rather on seeing Nathalie she'd been waved in automatically, or perhaps that was *habitually*?

Though perhaps that wasn't so strange. He was working for someone notoriously opposed, especially in the last few years, to interacting with strangers. Maybe once they got more comfortable with each other the Atelier would cease to be off bounds to Claude. Perhaps Mlle. Sancoeur was trying to avoid professional offence by making it obvious how differently she'd been working with M.Agreste to how she'd been.

That was the prosaic explanation and Claude wished he could believe it but certain things still didn't add up. That would suggest a comfortable working relationship between them and her hesitancy today hadn't been the first time Mlle. Sancoeur had seemed loath to draw their employer's attention and it seemed like more than an attempt to hide any discrepancy in their treatment.

If she'd been hiding her illness in an attempt to stay at work then that was pointless now. He thought back to initial question on his first day as to whether there had been a falling but if the signs of M.Agreste favouring Mlle.Sancoeur were slight then the signs of him being unhappy with her were non-existent.

Claude resisted the urge to bury his head in his hands. No doubt if he did so that would be the minute Nathalie would reappear and he had no interest in giving her the impression he couldn't handle the job. The job was *fine,* he was quite capable of doing the *job,* and he just need to ignore the rest of it and focus on that.

It was probably the move from working in the offices with the lots of other people to working in this mausoleum of a house with only Nathalie & the Agrestes to that was unsettling him. Once he adapted his brain would stop trying to generate conspiracy theories but even Elodie wouldn't take seriously.

He looked at the clock. Nathalie seemed to be taking a long time but at least it was almost the end of the workday and soon he'd be able to go home and forget about the Agrestes for a bit.

Unfortunately at that point a blonde head poked out the side of the doorframe followed by an "Um, Monsieur?"

"Yes Adrien?" he answered his hopes for a punctual end of the day collapsed and he wracked his brain as to whether he'd forgotten a photoshoot for the boy. He was sure none of his usual evening extracurriculars fell this day of the week.

"Is Nathalie around?"

"She's in with your father."

"Oh." Adrien almost sighed clearly disappointed but without any real surprise. Claude attempted not to mentally file this as further evidence that Mlle Sancoeur had worked far more closely with their boss than he was set up to be doing.

The boy remained hovering in the doorway awkwardly holding a laptop which at least didn't seem to suggest he expected to head off to a photoshoot.

If Adrien had a query about scheduling something then it would be Claude's sole responsibility to sort that out soon and he supposed he really should be getting the boy used to it. "Did you need something?"

"Um, I was going to ask her to look over my essay before I printed it off."

"Does she usually do that sort of thing?"

"I guess? I mean I'm generally ahead at school but I can't really ask my Father."

"No. I suppose not." Claude replied straining to keep his voice neutral as he glanced at his clock on his computer again, if Nathalie didn't appear soon then those documents were going to miss the post, and he was going to miss the end of his day. "Well I suppose I could have a look at it for you since she's busy."

He didn't recall helping Adrien with his homework being one of his job requirements but apparently it was so he'd best get used to it. He supposed it either fell under "minimising interruptions to M.Agreste" or "organising Adrien's day"

"Would you? It's not the content, she doesn't do my work for me, but I just need someone to make sure it makes sense and there's no obvious errors."

"And that's all?"

The boy blushed. "Well, Nathalie says I can be a bit long-winded at times and gets me to cut bits down, but I'm not expecting you to do that." His embarrassment made Claude wonder if perhaps this wasn't in fact part of his job requirements, but the boy was so undemanding he could easily see how Mlle. Sancoeur might feel the need to help him out more than was professionally demanded, especially after his mother disappeared.

"Well give it here then."

Adrien passed over his laptop. "Should I sit here" he gestured at Nathalie's chair "while you go through it?"

"Hmm? That seems unnecessary-I'm sure a boy your age has more interesting things to do with your time, I'll review it and flag anything necessary up the way I do for your father and send it back to you."

"Oh ok. That's not how, I mean sure that makes sense." Said Adrien though it took him longer than Claude expected to leave given he'd have thought Adrien would be delighted by the idea of more free time. Still evidently the change in staffing was going to be as much as an adjustment for Adrien as his father even if the teenager was significantly more polite about it.

The essay was well written as far as Claude could tell although it had been a long time since he'd been exposed to this sort of writing. Business formal was its own animal and the crossover between it and school essay writing lay mostly in the lack of informality.

Nor could he remember much of book it was about to know how correct Adrien's reading of it was but it seemed an intelligent argument being put forth in the esssay at least.

He read through the essay adding comments where Adrien seemed to have become too caught up in his argument to check precisely what he was writing and tried not to keep glancing at his on screen clock.

Nathalie continued to not return from the Atelier.

When he got to the end of the essay he saved it and sent a text off to Adrien letting him know it was ready for him. He looked over towards the Atelier again then at his phone. Neither Nathalie nor the documents had re-appeared and at this rate they'd miss the post anyway so there seemed little point in him waiting to take them out to the street for collection whatever he'd offered Nathalie earlier.

Decision made he shut down his computer and picked up his coffee cup to rinse out in the kitchen. He'd made the mistake of leaving it overnight in an office once and the science experiment that resulted was enough to stop him doing it ever again even if he was already late finishing work.

He headed to the kitchen and washed up the mug in the sink. As he put the coffee cup down he heard a crash come from the direction of the offices.

Rushing towards the sound he almost crashed into Adrien running the opposite direction.

The boy barely stopped to blurt "Can you get the first aid kit? I need to find Gorilla," before running on.

Claude turned back towards the kitchen and grabbed the kit before sprinting back towards the direction Adrien had come from.

He found Nathalie lying cradled in their kneeling employer's arms with half her face covered in blood which was dripping on the floor.

He'd not known what to expect but he was still frozen by the sheer amount of blood. He couldn't even see the wound itself but he realised it had to be somewhere under the pool of blood on her forehead the flow seemed to vaguely originate from.

"Stop standing there and give me something to stop this with." snapped M.Agreste breaking him out of his frozen shock.

Claude fumbled with the catch and found a box labelled first aid dressing. Why they made these things so hard to open he would never understand.

He passed the white material over to M.Agreste who almost snatched it from him and pressed it to Nathalie's head. Thankfully she seemed conscious but while she was sat more upright now she remained reliant on M.Agreste support to remain there.

Claude hovered unsure of what help he could offer.

"Should I ring for an ambulance?"

"That's unnecessary. We'll be faster driving to the hospital than waiting for one."

Nathalie pressed her hands to the floor to push herself further up and something in Claude's chest relaxed at the sight even as she started to speak "It looks worse than it is anyway."

"Nathalie you can't see it," said M.Agreste "You're probably going to need stitches."

Adrien ran back with his bodyguard who helped the two of them up and helped bundle Nathalie into the car. Adrien took the first aid kit off him in case they needed something more to dry up the blood and ran into the car after them leaving Claude feeling like a total idiot for having less sense in an emergency than a fourteen year old.

He sighed and looked back at the hallway. He hadn’t been left with any instructions but the least he could do was clear this up. The cleaning service wasn't supposed to come until Thursday and even if he could move them to tomorrow he could hardly leave this here overnight for the Agrestes to come back to once they returned from the hospital.

He texted Elodie saying he’d be even later and he’d explain when he got home.

Looking over the mess he noticed first the bottom half of the glass Nathalie usually kept with her to sip from during the day and then smaller shards shattered about. He supposed that explained the blood-she must have tripped holding it or something similar. Better that than hitting your head hard enough to cut it or whatever he’d thought had happened.

The documents she’d gone in to show to M.Agreste lay on their desk mocking him. Rationally he had no responsibility for what had happened today but that didn’t stop him from googling the later post collection in Paris to seen them over to.

Chapter 2

Until he'd actually entered the mansion Claude had been able to put what had happened to the back of his mind. People had to go to hospital to get cuts glued or stitched up all the time and she'd gone before the nightly post bar rush. There had been no real mystery to the situation-he'd known she had dizzy spells and there was the broken glass he'd found.

It was a little too neat that it was the last day she had been scheduled to work, but coincedences happened and really that was a lucky one. Perhaps it was an irregular way to handover a job but that was it, and he kept telling himself that.

However once he was inside he couldn't stop feeling on edge. He worked in an office, or he had until now; it wasn't as if he was accustomed to blood in his workplace.

He tried to tell himself that he was being silly and he needed to get back to work, and with some panic he remember that that started with making sure Adrien got off to school alright, or at very least contacting the school if it turned out he hadn't had enough sleep at night to make it. So despite how it still felt like he was intruding when he sat anywhere in the house *other* than his office he went in search of the boy.

The last thing he expected to find instead was for Nathalie Sancoeur to be sat at the breakfast bar in leggings and an oversized jumper. A dressing covered by what looked like a large transparent plaster covered her right temple.

Seeming completely unware of the oddity of her existence there she said, "Ah, is that Adrien's schedule? I can go through it with him if you want to make a start on answering emails. The coffee machine is over there if you want one."

Years of work meant he was unable not to offer any response but he was also too confused to come up with anything better than "Um."

"I would advise taking one in for M.Agreste before his 9:30 conference call, but until he gets used to you it's best you try and minimise in person contact time with him."

"Right." He answered. The small part of his brain that delighted in the confirmation of his suspicions regards her working practices was drowned out by the larger part that was screaming about what on earth was going on.

Claude decided to take up her suggestion of getting himself a coffee.

Perhaps after that it would make sense why the woman he was replacing, who was supposed to have finished work yesterday, who he'd seen literally collapse in a pool of blood yesterday was sat in the Agreste mansion and talking about scheduling.

Surely the company couldn't be expecting her to make up for the hours she hadn't completed yesterday, because again she'd *collapsed in a pool of blood.*

Before his thoughts could spiral further into what job exactly he'd signed up for Adrien ran into the room looking far too awake for someone who must have got back from the hospital at goodness knows what time.

"Nathalie! You're up! I was going to check on you but Father said not to disturb you. Are you feeling better?"

"Thank you for asking Adrien, I'm much better than yesterday. Honestly."

"Good. You're still staying though right?"

"For the next few days at least. Anyway you should be eating rather than talking. M.Berger here has your schedule to go through."

"About that Mlle.Sancoeur, I might take you up on your earlier offer."

She took the tablet from him with far more pleasure than anybody should ever show when given anything work related. Especially when said someone was clearly too ill to be doing any work.

He attempted to get through his emails (and those forwarded from her out of office) on his phone while she went through the boy's day with him but it was hard to concentrate as he rapidly rethought his ideas of Nathalie Sancoeur's relationship with the Agrestes if she was *living with them* now.

Once Adrien left with his driver he looked back up at her.

"So you're living here?"

She rolled her eyes. "That's overstating it. After my turn yesterday M.Agreste and Adrien wouldn't hear of me going home in case another attack came on, and there was no one there to help. I'll manage to escape once they calm down in a few days."

The hairs on his arms stood up on end. "Escape?"

"Metaphorically." She looked unconcerned but then she usually *did,* "it's not worth the argument and I wouldn't want to upset Adrien. Besides I can't pretend there aren't advantages in being here rather my apartment. Better coffee for one."

"I see." He took a sip of his coffee. "What exactly happened yesterday? Is there anything I should be doing to help?"

He did not add "Should you even be out of bed?" though he was sorely tempted to. He thought you had to monitor people after head injuries but he wasn't actually sure what for. Were you supposed to keep them awake or was that something else? If victims were supposed to stay awake then he supposed that would explain her being out of bad.

"I fainted I think. I've been having dizzy spells as part of my condition but it's not usually that bad. Unfortunately I happened to be holding a glass at the time and it shattered hence my lovely accessory." She gestured towards the dressing.

He supposed it fit with scene he'd found.

"But you're ok?"

"I don't have a concussion or anything if that's what you mean. It doesn't really even hurt that much. I'll be fine, even if it's a bad place for a scar."

"Well that's something I suppose," He mentally grasped for a non-awkward way to end the conversation "Time's getting on, I should be getting to work."

He liked to think he did not flee the kitchen for the comparative freedom of his office.

Whatever was going on here it wasn't the coffee keeping Nathalie Sancoeur here; Of that much he was sure.

It did make sense to stay around other people if you were going to be randomly fainting and injuring yourself but, while he might have to give M.Agreste the slight credit that he clearly did care for his former assistant after all apparently, he didn't understand why she was here and not with her family or at least with friends.

He tried to concentrate on his work and one advantage of the barrage of emails life had decided to send him today was that at least he had little time to wonder at what exactly what going on.

Idiot suppliers and customers were within his capabilities and besides it wasn't as if he'd have to dig through his predecessors emails to discover what was going on with any disputes because apparently his predecessor was going to be here indefinitely!

Work may not have been as good a distraction as he'd hoped.

Still it did mostly drown out the chorus of utter confusion in his day until M.Agreste rang through and in the first time since Claude had known him actually asked after his son this morning.

It was admittedly an almost rhetorical question about whether Adrien had got to school alright thrown in after a conversation about the business but considering Claude would have wondered if M.Agreste knew he had a son if not for the boy being the face of his brand this was pretty earth shattering.

So while he had the sense not to admit he'd let her do part of his job he hadn't thought much of saying "and he seemed glad to see Nathalie at breakfast" at the end of his sentence.

From the silence before any response this was a mistake.

"What."

Unsure where exactly he'd gone wrong he repeated. "Adrien got off to school fine and seemed relieved to see Nathalie at breakfast?"

He wished for once that his employer would just make normal phone calls instead of video calls and he could have been spared the glare being bestowed on him.

“Why was Nathalie at breakfast?”

“I.don’t know sir. I suppose she was hungry?”

He realised he probably sounded like a bit of an idiot but he didn’t think he quite deserved the condescension in his boss’ voice when he replied. “You suppose she was hungry.”

“She was there when I arrived sir, I didn’t ask her why.”

M.Agreste pressed his fingers to his temples and exhaled before saying “Please inform me if she comes downstairs again.”

He then cut the call.

Claude wondered if this was the end of it as he added “Monitoring Nathalie Sancoeur” to his updated mental job description which continued to increase day by back from the one that HR had sent him over originally. He could probably get them for false advertising or something.

But moments later he got confirmation that M.Agreste was *not* satisfied by the video call as he heard a door slam followed by steps upstairs.

Claude gingerly propped the door to his office open to listen for any sound. Technically Mlle. Sancoeur wasn’t his colleague anymore so it wasn’t his place to intervene in any argument between M.Agreste and his, well, whatever exactly Nathalie Sancoeur was to him.

Besides had it been Elodie hurt like that yesterday then he probably wouldn’t have been very happy at her getting out of bed either, and he’d ignored far less justified arguments between the people he’d worked for and their families.

Still she *had* said escape even if she was joking, and Mme.Agreste *had* disappeared without explanation, and it just didn't seem right not to at least listen.

But no sounds reached downstairs. He supposed that was a good thing. The house was too large for him to hear normal conversation from the upper floors and who knew what room she was even in, but he would have noticed yelling even if he wouldn't have been able to make it out.

Through the open door he saw M.Agreste come back down the stairs and return to his office. He didn't look happy but then Claude has never actually seen him looking happy.

He got out his phone and texted Nathalie “R u ok?”

He got back “Tell M.Agreste I’m fine.”

He wasn’t sure whether to be insulted at the suggestion he’d only ask after her health if told to by his employer.

His phone buzzed again but it was Elodie, not Nathalie, asking if he'd seen the latest on the Ladyblog. He texted back "not yet" and pulled the website up on his phone expecting to see reports of a new Akumatision though he hadn't had any news alerts on his phone.

Though Paris was overdue for a Hawkmoth attack and the Ladyblog *did* tend to outpace traditional news sources on Ladybug and Chat Noir news. How a teenager kept outperforming actual professionals on Ladybug and Chat Noir news he'd never understand.

Instead he got a rather perplexing headline.

HAWKMOTH STOPPED AKUMATIZING ME

Beneath was a video interview with the not-akumatized almost victim. He didn't think he could get away with looking at it now so he'd have to look later but based on the written summary below it sounded like the man *had* been akumatized but then Hawkmoth had withdrawn his powers before he could actually do anything.

Claude wondered at the teenage boy volunteering for this interview; having actual supervillain Hawkmoth decide you couldn't be trusted with powers was a strange thing to want bandied around.

Of course the website offered other suggestions, although the idea the supervillain identity the boy had developed was too weak or otherwise too ridiculous for Hawkmoth's intentions also sounded rather embarrassing for the boy given the existence of that pigeon one.

The theories about Hawkmoth weakening were interesting though. It was true there had been a reduction in the frequency of akuma attacks recently and there hadn't been any in the last fortnight but Claude found the assumption that maybe the Paris' magical terrorism problem would just sort itself out to be rather over-optimistic.

He fired off a text to Elodie saying he'd just read it but hadn't watched the video and it was very odd.

He considered sending another text regarding the utter insanity he'd found himself in at work but decided it was a conversation better had in person. Besides which he did have actual work to do.

He heard a car pull up outside and realised it must be lunchtime and Adrien had returned.

He saved the document he was working on and started towards the door of the office but by the time he entered the lobby the boy had let himself in and made a beeline upstairs leaving his bodyguard behind by the doorway.

"Should I be making sure they both eat?" he asked the silent bodyguard.

The other man just shrugged and walked off.

Under usual circumstances Adrien was self-sufficient enough that supervising his lunch was unnecessary, though Mlle. Sancoeur had been known to do so, but these weren't usual

circumstances and Claude still wasn't sure exactly what his responsibilities regarding Nathalie Sancoeur entailed.

He'd essentially been told she was meant to be resting in bed rather than coming down for whatever she felt like, but he hadn't been told to bring anything to her, and while she'd been joking about the quality of the coffee earlier based on the amount she normally drank at work she must have been in caffeine withdrawal at this point.

Whether caffeine withdrawal or incurring M.Agreste's displeasure was worse was arguably a difficult point to prove, but she'd apparently chosen the former over the latter.

He picked up the phone considering. It was exceedingly tempting to hand the issue back up the line. Adrien was M.Agreste's son, and Nathalie was M.Agreste's…*something* anyway. He supposed guest was the most relevant descriptor, and it wasn't incorrect.

He gathered his confidence. His boss might have a hair trigger temper but it wasn't like the company could fire him for this.

"Yes?"

"Your son's just arrived back. Were you planning to eat with him and Mlle. Sancoeur?"

"I'm working," the man said, and then something broke through his glacial façade, "Has Nathalie come down to see Adrien then?"

"He went up to see her," he clarified.

The man nodded as if satisfied. "Have lunch sent up to them there then."

"So how did it go last night? Or did the great man not deign to inform you about your colleague's health?" Elodie asked when she got in from work.

Pretending nonchalance he said. "Oh, he didn't need to. I saw her myself-she's fine by way, it was just an unfortunate shard of glass."

"You saw her?" she interrupted "Did she have stuff to pick up from work or?"

He looked up, anticipating a normal person's reaction to this with some relish. "Apparently she's living there now."

"What."

He turned the hob down to prevent the vegetables overboiling enjoying someone else sharing his utter confusion when everyone else in the Agreste household had acted as if all of this

was normal. “Apparently she lives alone and after last night the Agrestes were concerned about no one being around if anything else happened.”

With her hand to her chest in faux-offence she gasped, “How did you not tell me this earlier?”

“Because one of us being distracted by my employer’s bizarre home life is enough.” He’d struggled enough to get any work down at work without Elodie ignoring her own to ask him for a play by play of it.

“I mean, fair, but please don’t deny me gossip.”

He sighed. “Please don’t call it that. I’m fairly certain I’m supposed to reduce gossip about the people I work for not add to it.”

“Oh alright. Please tell me, as your trusted partner, about the weird things you have to deal with at work.

“Thank you.”

She went to the cupboard to get out two wine glasses and he couldn’t even find it in himself to point out it was a weeknight. At this point he figured he deserved it.

Placing one of them down by him she said, “So like are they together or what?”

“What?”

“Gabriel Agreste and Nathalie Sancoeur?”

Putting their names together like that suddenly made him realise what she was asking. “Are you asking if they’re *dating*?”

“Yes” she said emphatically.

“God no.” Claude shuddered at the image. That was the last thing he wanted to have flash in front of his eyes the next time he saw either of them. “No. *No.* Why would you even suggest that?”

She looked at him oddly. “It’s the less weird explanation.”

That was not what *he’d* call it at all. He knew what relationships looked like. He was *in* a relationship. Hell, he’d seen M.Agreste in a relationship. Whatever was going on here was something else entirely. “How is it less weird?”

“Because moving in with your partner is normal, while a guy who hates human contact, and from what you’ve said barely talks to his employees except for vital work stuff, asking one of them, and one who’s already scheduled time off for medical reasons at that, to stay because he’s worried about her is not.”

Put like that he could see where she was coming from. And maybe *he'd* have thought the same if he didn't know the people in question, but he *did.* And besides, "I mean she's not exactly just any employee. She's worked for him for over a decade and the last few years of that were just the two of them alone in his house."

"You know, I know you and I know you think that makes things sound more above board, but if there really is nothing going on, I really hope for their sake you're not in charge of issuing their denial statements."

"What was wrong with that?"

"Um, alone in his house with him for a few years? Yeah I know how your work is set up *and* that that's not quite true with the kid and the bodyguard and everything, but other people don't, and he's a rich widower and she's a younger women so people are naturally going to imagine things."

"He's not technically a widower you know." And he didn't think Nathalie was that much younger. And though he'd never thought about it he supposed she was attractive enough in a buttoned-up sort of way despite how run down she looked all the time but it wasn't as if their employer couldn't have his pick of stunningly beautiful models he could chose in the alternative universe where he decided to give up on his beloved wife. That was the advantage of being rich after all.

"Please," Elodie said, "there's no way Emilie Agreste is still alive at this stage, and literally no one thinks she is."

"Well you never know. No one would have thought superheroes existed before this year. That's beside the point though-it's down to the brand's PR to make any statements not me."

"Lucky for them. It *is* weird though."

"Oh I'm not denying *that*." Much of him just wanted to kiss his girlfriend for vindicating his feelings on it but he *did* have dinner to make. "I'd never expected to be asked to inform him if she came downstairs when she's supposed to be resting when I started this job."

Elodie frowned at him. "Are you sure there's nothing between them?"

"Not in that way. He's still clearly hung up on his wife. There's not nothing between the two of them though. I think they used to work more closely together before I came in. I'm not sure if there was some falling out, or if it's just her working around his aversion to strangers or work, or what, but I suppose it's not unnatural that he'd worry about her."

"Or if they were trying to hide something?"

"I suppose, but I can't think what."

Elodie put her glass down to say something but he interrupted before she could "And don't say an affair. Or Mme.Agreste's murder. Or an affair that led to Mme. Agreste's murder."

She shrugged in defeat. "I don't think it was a falling out anyway."

“Yeah, I think I was barking up the wrong tree there.” Even before her injury that hadn’t seemed right. *She* might have been trying to hide something from *him,* but their employer certainly didn’t seem to bear her any ill will and it was *very* obvious when Gabriel Agreste was unhappy with you.

Which was honestly one of the only things stopping him from asking her if she needed a rescue because M.Agreste’s apparent assumption he had the right to control her convalescence the same way he ordered her around at work made him uncomfortable. It would have been easier to shrug off if he thought they *were* together.

“Could just be friends, and hiding it from you because they felt it was unprofessional. Though I still think the affair idea explains it more.”

“To you. As someone who’s met actually met the people in question, she’s too sensible and professional to do that sort of thing, and I don’t think I’ve ever seen him show an emotion other than annoyance.”

“That’s a bit unfair. I’m sure he’s happy when his show’s go off well, and he *was* married”

From what Claude had heard the main descriptor of the designer at his fashion shows was “terrifying” but he didn’t think it was worth raising that point. “Yeah to someone he idolised, and has been in no rush to declare dead.”

He literally had a *stature* of her in his garden. It felt sometimes more like the house was missing the sun it had orbited or it’s creator-goddess rather than a normal human woman.

They fell silent as they ate but eventually Elodie piped up “Why is she there though? Doesn’t she have anyone else she could stay with?”

“I don’t know actually.” He’d been so thrown at her being there that he hadn’t considered why she wasn’t somewhere else. “I know there’s no boyfriend but she’s never really spoken about her life outside work. She’s not really the open sort.”

“Huh. Maybe her family live far away, or aren’t close, and she’d know he’s got the room to spare-it’s not like letting her have a room is some great sacrifice.”

Claude decided not to bring up that “letting her have a room” was rather underselling the situation. He’d wanted verification from someone else that the situation was as odd as he thought but he hadn’t wanted to hear ideas that were going to make it even harder to pretend he didn’t notice anything odd at work. Unlike Elodie he had to actually look these people in the eye.

“No, not really, and he *was* worried about her yesterday, hell, I was worried about her yesterday and I haven’t known her for years. It was a very worrying scene to walk into. It’s not that odd he might have extended the offer, if only to reassure Adrien.”

“Oh yeah, you mentioned the boy was there. Are they close?”

“She does more of his parenting than his father does.” Not unusual for a man of that type though he thought it odd in some ways that Adrien didn’t have a designated nanny for that, though it was possible that the boy had when he was younger.

“Huh, maybe Agreste just thinks this way he can keep things that way even though she’s not working for him anymore.”

“That’s the most plausible thing you’ve said all evening *and* it would go someway to explaining why he kept her on so long, when it turns out he isn’t completely heartless about her health.”

Chapter 3

The mansion, Claude was starting to suspect, was haunted.

And not by Emilie Agreste either.

Or it *was* by Emilie Agreste's absence and the gaping spaces she'd apparently left between father and son, and between her husband and it seemed sometimes like the entire rest of the world apart from Mlle. Sancoeur.

But that was a mundane sort of haunting.

A metaphorical one.

Even if sometimes with the ever-present chill in the house he felt it quite easy to believe *her* spirit pervaded the house too ensuring its inhabitants could never forget her. She'd always commanded attention when she'd been alive. He remembered that much from his few encounters with her.

Though if she *was* haunting the house that was only the start of it.

He'd hear voices in empty rooms, and odd noises at strange times. Once when he'd been forced to work late in the run-up to fashion week he thought he'd heard a thump from Adrien's room only to find the boy safely asleep when he went looking.

And there was the strange matter of the cheese. When taking her lunch once he'd taken the opportunity to ask Nathalie if M.Agreste was particularly fond of camembert given the amount of it in the fridge, thinking it might be a chance to get on his boss' good side by arranging for it to be served more.

She'd told him that it was actually *Adrien's* particular favourite, and that for reasons beyond her the boy had started ordering it himself rather than asking her to. She'd adding it to the weekly list since, in the hope that the boy would remember that though he father might not let him do everything he wanted he *was* allowed to ask for things.

All of which was a little bit odd but nothing strange in an otherworldly way. After all M.Agreste and Mlle. Sancoeur seemed to have basically trained Adrien *out* of asking for things even if they hadn't meant to. He was the most well behaved teenager Claude had ever met.

No. The supernatural part was how Claude had got some milk out of the fridge to put in the coffee machine and when he'd gone to put it back out there had been a bite taken out of the wheel of cheese.

A bite that had *not* been there before.

And it wasn't a human sized bite either.

Not an adult human one anyway but there was just something *off* about it. The teeth marks looked wrong somehow and besides, unless M. Agreste had a secret baby hidden around somewhere then Adrien was the youngest person in the house.

Claude was fairly certain M.Agreste didn't have a secret baby hidden somewhere around the house.

And besides humans weren't invisible, not unless they'd been caught in an akuma attack anyway, but he swore that the fridge door hadn't even opened. He'd have noticed that. Yet somehow there had been no bite mark before and there had been afterwards.

Quite possibly he owed his old Breton grandmother an apology for laughing about all her stories about pixies, since now he had no idea what you were supposed to do to appease them. Some vague story about leaving out milk for fairies hovered in his mind but he kind of thought it ended up with the fairies turning the milk sour.

And besides it seems very clear that what this particular pixie, brownie, fairy whatever, wants is cheese and they're clearly already providing that.

Or *Adrien* is, and the thought comes to mind that maybe *he* can see whatever invisible cheese-eating beings are in the house, but asking the boy seems like a dangerous idea.

Grapes also seem to disappear at odd times but he's fairly certain that's M.Agreste.

The fact that sometimes he seems to only one or two at a time is odd but thoroughly within the sort of oddness he's used to expecting. At least *this* fashion designer doesn't order dozens of crème brûleés just to crack the surface when he's depressed.

Besides despite the fact that his role seems to continue and to continue increasing in scope he doesn't think that dealing with magical infestations is actually part of it.

He's still started googling the best ways to contact either Ladybug or Chat Noir. They say akumas are magic so he figures that whatever is going on in the Agreste house is squarely within their ballpark.

Not that he's said anything yet because that would just be embarrassing with the lack of proof he has.

Besides which none of the weirdness exactly seems *dangerous.*

Or none of the magical weirdness anyway.

His boss is another matter.

The theories about Mme. Agreste's disappearance still don't sit right with Claude. It doesn't seem to explain what's going on.

There is however *something* going on.

For a start Nathalie Sancoeur is still living in the house. Or in one of the upstairs bedrooms anyway, since she rarely seems to venture out and he's honestly not sure if she's physically unable to, or if M.Agreste isn't letting her.

No one else in the household seems to think this is odd.

Not M.Agreste, who Claude could hardly dare to ask anyway.

Not his son, who seems to act as in her installation in his house is a perfectly natural state of affairs.

Not said son's bodyguard, who seems to have a blasé disinterest in the goings on of the Agrestes that Claude only *wishes* he could emulate.

As for the chief-

"Ah, is that Mlle. Sancoeur's?" Claude nods at a steaming bowl of soup next to the lunch he plans to take in to M.Agreste.

The chef nods not looking away from the meal plan for the week in front of him and that makes Claude wonder, "Do *you* know how long she's staying?"

After all he must have to count her into meal planning.

"I only get informed of expectations a week in advance," the chef says, "not that they don't all change their minds anyway."

"I'm sorry," Claude says, struck by how M.Agreste had locked himself in the Atelier and made himself completely incommunicado yesterday lunchtime with how busy they were, while Adrien hadn't been able to get home because of an akuma attack. Or akuma and amok attack the way they all seemed to be these days.

"Why?" The other man says, "it's not *your* fault the whole family's incapable of sticking to any plans. It's a miracle *he* manages to run a company somehow. It used to drive Nathalie mad in the old days. Of course now,"

"Now?"

"She's nearly as bad as the rest of them. It's osmosis from being around the Agreste's for too long I guess," he patted his shoulder, "don't worry, I'm sure it will take some time before it infects you."

"*Me?* I don't," Claude spluttered, "this is supposed to be a temporary thing. I hardly *see* M.Agreste. And wait, are you saying *Adrien* is as flaky as his father?"

The other man shrugs, "I suppose you haven't been here long enough. You'll see,"

"I will?" He edges away uncomfortable, "maybe I should take that soup up to Mlle. Sancoeur. I'm sure she'll want it before it gets cold."

“Hmm,” the chef said, “you’d think so anyway. Though the Madame always seemed to prefer things cooler near the end. The heat hurt her throat rather than soothing it.”

“You’re making her the same food for her you made for Mme. Agreste when *she* was ill?”

“M.Agreste’s command.”

“I see,” but he *didn’t.* He didn’t at all, and he stared at the chef as if it he looked at him harder he could tell if he was the type of man who would poison two women on their employer’s orders.

It didn’t make sense. M. Agreste had loved his wife. He seemed genuinely concerned for his former assistant to the extent that Claude had ever seen him show a real emotion.

He tried to calm down as he went up the stairs. It was probably just an attempt to be helpful. Thinking that what had helped before was what would help now.

And actually what *might* actually explain a lot of it was if Nathalie’s illness was bringing up a lot of memories of his wife’s illness and there was some sort of emotional transference thing going on.

It would certainly explain why he seemed to think he had the *right* to make decisions about his assistant’s convalescence.

Elodie’s idea of their relationship *not* being platonic almost came to mind again but he dismissed it. She was after all in her own room not *his,* thank god. And besides he clearly still considered himself married and despite his myriad of faults, and the many rumours Claude had heard about the brand’s designer over the years, none of them had included inappropriate behaviour with any woman who wasn’t his wife.

Unfortunately the woman he’d come up to give the soup to was asleep.

Awkwardly he put the soup down on the chest of drawers and put his hand on her shoulder in an attempt to wake her, “Mlle. Sancoeur?”

She mumbled something but didn’t wake up. He looked uneasily around the room at the various medical paraphernalia and wondered not for the first time *what* illness exactly it was she had, and whether she shouldn’t actually be in a hospital rather than here.

He supposed it was a *nicer* place to be than a hospital but he’d still not managed to figure out exactly what her relationship with his boss was that made any of this make sense.

As if summoned by his thoughts her eyes flickered open, “Gabriel?”

Gabriel?

What equanimity he'd regained was shattered by that.

"Uh, no, it's Claude," he forget her usual insistence on surnames so thrown at her calling M. Agreste by *his* first name. Which shouldn't have been that weird. She was living in the man's house after all. And yet it *was,* when he'd never seen his address her former boss as anything other than sir. "I brought you soup."

"Oh," she said, and seemed to drop back into sleep.

"Nathalie," he tried again. He really didn't have that much free time before he had to get back to work, and it didn't seem right to leave her without making sure she ate.

Unless the soup was poisoned.

It probably wasn't poisoned.

Probably.

M.Agreste was many negative things.

Ill-tempered, more often than not these days.

Difficult, in that way that only got called eccentric when you're rich.

Neglectful, of a son in that way that many rich men were which made you wonder why they had children at all.

But he wasn't *stupid.*

And he knew the importance of a public image.

He'd have to know how bad it would look for his wife to get ill before she went missing, and then for his assistant to do the same thing.

Besides despite his dislike for the man he *still* thought it was a bit of a stretch to think him capable of murder, and he'd continue to say that to anyone who claimed otherwise.

If anything how he'd put his former assistant up in her illness suggested there was a soft centre under that crusty exterior.

Whether he was just incapable of knowing how to show it Claude didn't know, and he honestly didn't care that much either. If everything went as planned then there was no reason to think he'd be here long enough to have any chance of seeing it.

What he *did* care about was the fact that there was no real reason to be worrying about what was going on between his employer and the woman whose role he'd taken over, and he needed to be sensible and remember that.

It was just it was so easy to *forget* in this house.

In fact despite the concerning image of Mlle. Sancouer herself who showed no sign of waking it was almost easier to relax here in her room, which at least *felt* like someone's room in their home, rather than seeming more like something for display than for living in like the rest of the house did.

Nathalie made a noise as if in pain drawing his attention back to her.

Her eyes were open and she said, "did you say you brought something?"

"Soup. The chef made it. I just volunteered to bring it up."

"That was nice of you, but you don't have to worry about me. I know you must have better things to do."

He shrugged, "It's lunchtime, and I figured technically M.Agreste could walk in search of his if he wanted and you couldn't."

"You shouldn't put me ahead of M.Agreste, he *is* the one you're working for."

He tried not to look incredulous, as he tried to square how she could accept living in her boss' house but not a minor favour from a colleague, "Honestly I think *he* thinks I work for you as much as I do for Adrien."

It didn't seem possible she could be *unaware* of her current position in this household but perhaps it was easy to forget after so many years being on the opposite side of the equation.

"That's, I'm not," she gave up on answering, and went to try to push herself up. "Is Adrien behaving for you?"

"Yes," he told her, confused as to why everyone was acting like Adrien was something other than one of the most accommodating teenagers he'd ever dealt with, "I've had no issues with Adrien."

Her eyes narrowed, "but you have with his father?"

"I,"

"M.Agreste can be unpredictable but you'll get used to it." She huffed, "*I* did."

Yes, the whole situation certainly suggested that, but apart from the fact he had no instead in ending up in a situation like hers with their boss, "I don't know if I'll be saying long enough for that."

She shut her eyes for a second. "Right. Temporary. I keep forgetting."

It was a rather odd thing to forget when the *reason* it was temporary was because she was supposed to recover.

"I'll put a word in with M.Agreste though," she added a moment later, "he probably forgets it's not as easy for you to anticipate him as it was for me."

“Thanks, I’d appreciate that,” he looked her over again, “do you need some help getting up?”

His hand hovered awkwardly over her arm. He wasn’t really sure what was the most appropriate way to help her up.

“No I can do it,” she said, “I just feel exhausted. Which is ironic because I’m also bored out of my skull.”

It was more than she’d ever really admitted about her condition or how it was affecting her before.

He tried to lighten the mood. “I’d offer you work but I don’t think that would help with the exhaustion.”

“Probably not.”

Nathalie’s attention was suddenly caught by something behind him, and then his soul shrivelled up as he heard, “What exactly is going on here?”

He turned to face Gabriel Agreste.

“I was just bringing Nathalie up her lunch.” He justified himself.

“Did that require you to stay?”

“I was just making conversation.”

“I believe I pay you to *work,* not to sit around idly chatting. And I’m not sure feeding Nathalie is in your job description either.”

Maybe I’d have a better idea what was if you didn’t keep changing it.

“I’ll remember that sir.” He said blandly, “is there anything you need now, or can I leave you with Mlle. Sancoeur?”

His boss frowned like he planned to go on complaining longer, but after a moment he said, “That’s all. You’re dismissed.”

So much for concern, Claude thought as he left the room, it was hardly fair for him to ban the poor woman from any chance of in-person conversation with anyone other than him or maybe his son.

“It’s like whatever I do is wrong. Well I’m sorry but how am I supposed to know if she’s a colleague or someone I’m meant to be looking after when *he* keeps giving me conflicting orders?”

Elodie snorted, “I thought you said you were good at reading rich people’s minds.”

“*Normal* ones. Not ones like-” horrified he spotted Adrien looking at him, “sorry I have to go.”

Adrien’s hand went to the back of his neck, “sorry. I didn’t meant to interrupt.”

“It’s fine,” he reassured the boy as put the phone down, he *was* meant to be working, and he figured the teenager got ignored enough by his father without Claude mimicking him, “it was only my girlfriend.”

“Wait,” Adrien said, “you have a *girlfriend?*”

“uh, yes,” he'd be insulted at how the boy seemed to marvel at the idea, if it wasn't for the sheer admiration in his eyes, “i do.”

The concept couldn't be that alien to the boy. Sheltered as he was he did go to school.

“Um, so,” Adrien looked oddly hesitant, “could I ask you a question?”

“A question?”

“About dating?”

Claude stared at him, and wanted to point out that he was the boy’s father’s assistant, not his friend or his relation or anything that might make him an appropriate version for dating advice.

Maybe Nathalie Sancoeur might have had the sort of relationship that could make this make sense but *he* didn’t. He barely knew the boy.

And he definitely didn't know what his father would or wouldn't approve of with Adrien’s dating life.

“I'm not sure that would be appropriate,” he tried to let the boy down gently, “have you tried asking?”

Adrien raised an eyebrow, “My father?”

Claude glanced towards the wall separating them from o the Atelier and winced.

“Maybe at dinner?” he suggested weakly, “he’s supposed to be eating with you on Friday? Or maybe you could ask Nathalie?”

“Uh, I mean, I’m sure she’d want to help but, she’s, um” Adrien trailed off.

“Ill?” Claude suggested offering him a way out because in the silence the multitude of pitfalls there had suddenly loomed in front of him and it seemed a kinder out than pointing out she didn’t seem to have much of a life outside work if she was staying *here* rather than friends or

family, and certainly it was safer than bringing up whatever the hell was going on between her and Adrien's father.

"Yeah," Adrien clutched onto the suggestion, "I wouldn't want to bother her when she's not well."

"She might not mind a little bit of bothering," Claude suggested, "she's a bit fed up being stuck up there by herself I think."

He didn't see how M.Agreste could object to *Adrien* spending his free time visiting her. It wasn't like *he* was supposed to be working quite all the time in the mansion. And she deserved to get to speak to someone.

"But ah," he felt the need to clarify, "maybe not on that subject."

"No," Adrien said slightly more quickly.

"Or maybe you could ask," he remembered that he'd never actually seen Adrien's bodyguard speak and abandoned that object, "never mind. But I don't think it's my place to tell you to ask out a girl."

"Oh I wasn't going to ask that,"

Claude stared at him, "you weren't?"

"No, it's just. If a girl breaks up with you and you're sad about it, but then you realise that you're actually sad about the fact you upset her, rather than the fact you're not dating anymore is that bad?"

Adrien Agreste had always given all indications that he was reasonably emotionally well-adjusted despite his fame, wealth, and weirdness of his home-life. Which actually, Claude realised as he rapidly re-assessed his opinion of his employer's son, was sort of odd given the fact he'd lived through his mother's disappearance on top of everything else.

Either way it seemed like perhaps he *had* been effected by the weird unclear boundaries in his life because, "why would that be bad?"

He'd also apparently inherited his father's predicilation for secrecy given that Claude had had no idea Adrien *had* a girlfriend.

"Because maybe it meant I was never that interested in her like that after all, and that's unfair because she's my friend first and I don't want to have been lying to her?"

"I think *lying's* putting it on a bit strongly. Look, have you ever dated a girl before?"

"No?"

He wasn't sure why that answer had sounded so uncertain but, "so you're going to be figuring things out. I vaguely remember being a teenager. It's easy to make mistakes like that

when you're feeling these sort of feelings for the first time. All you need to do is decide not to date someone until you're sure you like them as more than a friend next time."

That had to be fairly safe anodyne advice to give. Even M.Agreste couldn't disagree.

"I guess that makes sense," Adrien said.

Perhaps it was the paranoia this place created in him but for some reason Claude had a sinking feeling telling Adrien that was going to go wrong somehow.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

Apologies in advance to Marinette, and also pigeons.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Claude collapsed onto the sofa, glad to finally be free of any responsibility. The only thing he wanted to do this evening other than go to bed was *maybe* to take a shower.

Elodie looked up in concern and stood up and sat down next to him. “Are you alright?”

That. He felt was a rather stupid question. “I got *turned into a pigeon.”*

It seemed quite obvious to him that this meant that he definitely not was not alright.

She looked at him with sympathy in her eyes, and yet she repeated. “Yes, but are you OK?”

“What part of I got turned into a pigeon wasn’t clear?”

She reached out to undo his tie. “It could have been worse.”

He felt like his eyebrows must be somewhere in his hairline. “Than being turned into a pigeon?”

“Hey, it’s not like this is our first brush with an akuma attack. And didn’t some of your colleagues get turned into statures or something?”

“*Gold* statures. That’s actually sort of cool, even if you’re,” his stomach dropped as he guessed they’d been temporarily dead essentially, rather than aware the way he’d been, but honestly he’d have preferred *not* to be aware and, “anyway, that’s right out of a myth. There’s no dignity in being turned into a pigeon.”

And being *knowing* that you were a pigeon. He shuddered again at how filthy he’d felt. Of all things to be he *had* to be a rat-with-wings that had probably eaten god-knows-what.

“Flying must have been cool though? Better than being a statue.” She offered in what he could only assume was an attempt at being helpful but which honestly made him wonder if his girlfriend had forgotten who he was.

Maybe she was thinking of an ex of or something.

“I hate flying in planes. Why would I like it as a bird?” If anyone thought being transformed into a bird was a good way to cure someone’s fear of flying he could now definitely say it

wasn't. "*And* at least they got transformed by Audrey Bourgeois. Getting victimised by her is essentially a rite of passage in the industry. *I* got transformed by Paris' No. 1 Pigeonophile/"

At that she finally seemed to start to grasp his point, conceding with a grimace, "He does seem a little obsessed."

His voice came up embarrassingly high as he yelped, "A *little?"*

"OK," she did something between a nod and a shrug, "a lot. But you have to remember the *real* one at fault is Hawk Moth."

"Is it though? I mean, ok it is," he clarified before she could disagree. Everyone knew that, "but if you think about it it's mainly teenagers he transforms for a reason. They're, you know, volatile. Most adults have themselves under control enough not to be akuamatised *once,* never mind hundreds of times."

"That sounded like experience. Problems with Adrien Agreste?"

"Not *with* him exactly. Though I wish he'd let me know *where* he was running to hide through an akuma attack but oh my god, *today.*"

He thinks that if he hadn't lived through it he'd never believe the whole story.

Elodie's always been more credulous than him when it comes to listening to stories and theories though.

She learnt in clearly fascinated, and part of him relaxed at the fact of his pigeon transformation not putting him off, "What happened?"

"So not only do I get to a shoot, and the only person in Paris to get akumatised a ridiculous amount of times is there because for some godforsaken reason he's been hired as a bird handler, *and* both he and Bob Roth try to claim his pet, tamed, whatever pigeons are doves,"

He'd really wanted to ask them just how stupid they thought he or M.Agreste *were.* Neither of them were blind.

Elodie frowned, "I think pigeons *are* doves technically. European rock doves or something aren't they?"

He looked at her in disbelief. "Not helpful."

Technicalities were technicalities. No one would watch that shoot and think they were seeing doves, a symbol of hope and peace, having than pigeons, the pests of the city streets.

His girlfriend accepted his correction. "OK go on,"

"So, and get this, Adrien is allergic to pigeons."

Her eyes-widened, "No!"

“Yes! And flipping Agreste points out the obvious-that they ARE clearly pigeons but does not bring up the fact they’re endangering his son?”

Absent he might be but until today Claude had never thought his employer didn’t care for his son. The amount he activities he’d scheduled for him rather suggested the opposite. Now he was starting to wonder if M.Agreste viewed then as developing a brand asset rather than giving his son the best start in life.

Elodie looked agreeably equally confused, “What? I thought he was protective verging on paranoid?”

“So did I until today, so I’m stood there wondering if this some sort of test because god knows I can totally see my predecessor being the one to deal with Adrien’s medical stuff and my boss not even remembering what Adrien’s allergic to. I mean she literally warned me about having to ensure feathers weren’t used in collections he was modelling, so I’m wondering, am *I* supposed to say something? Is this my job?”

“Oh my god,” and now she seemed gratifyingly horrified.

“And the kid’s trying to advocate for himself and getting shut down, so I have to intervene. And *then,”*

Her jaw dropped. “It gets worse?”

“Yeah. Because next thing I look around and there’s two random teenage girls by the pool. The pool which we’d exclusively hired and closed to the public.”

“Oof. I mean we’ve all been slightly too obsessive teenage fans,”

“Uh,” he suddenly wondered at her own teenage years, because she’d never told him about anything like this, “not all of us we haven’t.”

Elodie tilted her head in consideration, “OK that might be more of a girl thing to be fair, but actually sneaking in to see him? *That’s* taking it a bit far. Though at least they’re less likely to be like murdery-stalker types than an adult man would be.”

“That makes me feel so much better,” he says deadpan. “But stalker was *exactly* what I was thinking because let’s just say, these two did *not* look like paparazzi. So I go over there to throw them out, and I’m starting to think maybe I should have brought the tablet with me, because why the hell am I shielding obsessive fans from M.Agreste?”

“Because you’re uncomfortable with him around women after his wife, and whatever the hell is going on with his assistant?”

“That would be it.” He agreed. “So, I’m halfway through my ‘what the hell do you think you’re doing speech?’ and the one who seems like the ringleader claims they’re Adrien’s *friends.* Which I’m pretty unconvinced by until the other one who seems more embarrassed by the whole thing speaks up and she’s *Kagami Tsurugi.”*

She looked at him blankly. “Am I supposed to know who that is?”

“Um, Tsurugi Technologies? Ring a bell?*”*

Recognition crossed her face. “Wait. *That’s* the family of one of Adrien’s obsessive fans? I never really thought about who owned that. *Do* they still own that or is it just the name??”

“Oh no, they still own it. Agreste has some exclusive contract for them. And she fences with Adrien. She actually *is* his friend. So given that I recalculated and was about to march them to the changing room to get dressed instead of just throwing them out.”

“They were in their *swimsuits?”*

“Again, please don’t expect me to understand the minds of teenagers.” He still didn’t know what they’d meant to do. Did they think that Adrien was having a swimming lesson and they’d join him in the pool or something?

He continued his explanation anyway, “And then, the other girl who I assume is some sort of fame-hungry hanger-on tries to explain she just wants to get Kagami and Adrien back together as if we have time for that when Adrien’s working. Like seriously? Did everyone in this town get hit by crazy powder or something when I was out for a week?”

“Admittedly with Akumas I don’t think that’s actually impossible, but I don’t think that’s what happened here. I just think everyone remotely connected to the man you work for is super weird.”

He can’t even attempt to refute that.

“The best part of it is that I didn’t know who he was dating but Adrien had literally just told me about how he’d been dumped by a girl but he was actually glad because he thinks he just likes her as a friend anyway.”

“Oh my god.”

“So I’m trying to work out to how to say anything, or *if* I should even say anything because this is *so* not my job.”

“No,” Elodie agreed still looking a little like she’d just walked right into a pole, “it really isn’t.”

He was getting into finally getting to vent. “So then the flipping tablet goes *again,* and I have to go and get it because apparently my boss won’t oversee the shoot himself but still wants to micromanage it. And I swear to god, when I explain the situation he’s like “why don’t you use the girls rather than the pigeons then?” as if it we can even legally get two teenage girls to model for us with no parental permission, no contract, and no sort of chaperone?”

Sometimes Claude wondered how his boss still *had* a company, never mind how he’d built it in the first place.

“Maybe he’s just a bit removed from how these things actually work?”

Despite Elodie's best attempt her suggestion still sounding weak coming from her mouth as if she couldn't quite convince herself.

Which was almost funny when, "In fairness I would not be surprised. Maybe Nathalie used to chaperone these sorts of things? I have no idea. But Adrien's there blushing between these two girls looking *nothing* like a boy who's disinterested,"

"In his defence based on what you're told me about his homelife I'm not surprised his ideas of what relationships are like are dubious?"

She had a point.

"What," he snorted, "do you think his father sits him down and tells him that sometimes if you're worried a woman is going to leave you, then you can make sure she doesn't by poisoning her?"

"Possibly not that explicitly but," she bit her lip, "*do* you think he's poisoning her?"

"No. I mean I don't know. No. Probably not," he was trying to convince himself as much as her, because rationally he was pretty sure that, "No, I don't think he's *killing* her."

"He might not be."

Thrown by this change in Elodie's opinion he couldn't muster anything better than,"What?"

"Maybe it's some sort of Munchausen by proxy thing?"

"You think? Because he's recreating things from his wife's illness," he shook his head, it *would* fix better and it was more believable but, "I don't think she gets enough medical attention for that. *And,* I mean, it's not like he actually likes attention on *him,* instead of his son or his brand."

"Hmm, that does seem to nix that theory." She agreed, and he could see the cogs in her brain working still trying to come up for an explanation of what the hell was going on between Gabriel Agreste and Nathalie Sancoeur.

They've got off topic, "But anyway to get back to today I'm trying to explain the legal issues to M.Agreste, and Bob Roth actually seems to find it's a good idea too somehow. Adrien is no help because he's awkwardly flirting with his girlfriends, and the Pigeon guy is having a breakdown about some sanctuary he wants to build, then the tablet loses its Wifi connection and the next thing I know I'm a pigeon."

His skin was still crawling at the memory of it, and of how feathers had grown out through it.

"Hey," Elodie said, pressing a kiss to his cheek, "it's alright, you're not a pigeon *now.*"

"I'm never going to forget being one."

"Don't they have that emergency mental health support for akuma attacks? We could probably get you signed up for one?"

She had a point but the whole thing was so *embarrassing.* A pigeon.

“How did *you* deal with getting sucked up in a bubble that time?” Claude couldn’t imagine anything worse.

“It didn’t really bother me?” She shrugged somehow terrifyingly nonchalant, “Like sure, at first I was terrified it would burst but once I realised no one seemed to be targeting them and it seemed pretty sturdy I just sat back and waited for Ladybug and Chat Noir to do their thing. Honestly I kind of feel it’s like Hawk Moth gave me a free panoramic helicopter ride. It was kind of fun.”

He shuddered again, “I could not think of anything worse.”

“Claude,” her hand closed over his, “you’re been caught in akuma attacks before, what made this one so bad?”

“I’ve never been *transformed* before. I’ve been caught in stuff but I’ve always been *me,*” he doesn’t know how to get across the squirming sensation of his own body changing without his permission.

Now she really *did* look concerned. “Seriously, *do* you need therapy or something?”

“Unless you can find one that can stop me going completely paranoid at work I’m not sure it would be much help.”

“It’s not paranoia if somethings actually happening.” She pointed out.

He buried his head in his hands, “please don’t say that. It’s hard enough to be reasonable as it is.”

“Yes, you did tell me about the cheese-eating fairies and/or ghosts.” She sighed.

Their newest argument raised its head again. “The cheese eating fairies are real.”

“Claude,”

Elodie might disagreed but she wasn’t there. The more Claude was the more and more convinced he got that, “My grandmother was right all this time.”

He owed her so many apologies from how he laughed at her ideas and superstitions when he was younger.

His girlfriend shut her eyes in eyes in despair, clearly not yet convinced, “Claude,”

“Elodie, I went back to my computer and the screen was open on a Google search for Fourme D’Aubert. That *was not me.*”

“What did you do?”

“Order some, obviously.” It’s not like he had another option. “I’m not getting cursed. Hell, maybe *that’s* what happened to Nathalie and why M.Agreste is so *weird* about anyone being around her apart from him.”

She raised her hand in front of her, ““Ignoring the whole claiming-fairies-are-real thing for a moment, have you considered that that doesn’t even much logical sense when you literally told me she used to order the cheese?”

“Oh right.”

“Look. I’m not denying something strange and possibly nefarious is going on there. Hell, *I’m* the one of us that thought he killed his wife first. But once again I have to ask you are you sure the possessiveness isn’t just jealousy?”

“Why would he be *jealous* of me bringing her soup?”

She made a face as if she thought it ought to be obvious. “And sitting on her bed?”

He thought his soul was going to shrivel up, “this is your theory that there’s something between them again isn’t it?”

“I don’t know why you’re so against it.”

Firstly because imaging it made him die a little inside and secondly because, “There’s nothing romantic in this situation!”

“I didn’t say it was a good or healthy relationship. I mean it’s probably not.”

“If they were together then *why* isn’t she in his room?”

He felt quite proud of his point.

She didn’t seem to think it irrefutable proof.

“Because they’re trying to keep it secret from you, or because he hasn’t cleared all of his wife’s stuff out and he feels guilty and stuff so they’re both sleeping in her room, or maybe they’ve something but they’re not officially together yet. There are so many ways you could explain it.”

“Or they’re just not together.”

She pulled back a little shaking her head. “Why are you so convinced there’s nothing?”

“What would she even see in him? He’s a hermit and a neglectful father who’s still hung up on his dead wife with absolutely stupid hair and the interior design taste of a nouveau-riche Austrian money-launderer.”

“That last bit was weirdly specific.”

“I read an article, and now it haunts me that I’m never going to be able to describe the Agreste Mansion perfectly without plagiarising it.” Upscale lawyers office meets Apple Store is *exactly* the vibe of the house. He almost can’t believe there’s another one in existence that matches so perfectly.

“Anyway,” Elodie rolls her eyes, “I think you’re missing something.”

“What?”

He can’t see any reason *anyone* would ever want to date his boss.

She looks at him like he’s stupid. “He’s rich.”

“That would explain someone who didn’t know him being interested. Not Nathalie Sancoeur. Especially as she seems to be reaping the benefits of that *without* sleeping with him.”

“And he’s tall.”

As someone of a perfectly average height Claude shifted subconsciously. “Do women really care about that?”

“Some do. Is *she* tall? And does she wear heels?”

“Yeah,” he admitted. “And yeah on occasion.”

He’s never seen her in flats but her usual shoes don’t seem quite high enough to call heels. He’s seen higher ones in her room though.

“She probably does then.”

“Still though,”

“And. He’s not unattractive.”

“*What?*” He spluttered, “What are you talking about? You have seen him right? I know some people like cheekbones but *what?”*

Had she completely forgotten who they were talking about? *Gabriel Agreste?* Attractive?

“I’m not saying he’s conventionally attractive the way his son is but he’s striking. He’s definitely got something you know?”

“But,” he feels inexplicably betrayed by his girlfriend’s apparently horrible taste in men, “you think he’s a murderer.”

“That doesn’t mean I can’t think he’s hot. Like I wouldn’t date him for ten million euro because you know, probable murderer.”

“Thank you.” For once he’s not even going to attempt to defend his boss from that claim.

“But yeah, I think plenty of women would find him physically attractive enough.”

He stared into the middle-distance. “I’m appalled.”

“There, there.” She patted the top of his head. “Should *I* be worried?”

“What?”

“You never mentioned *him* not being interested in *her* as a reason? Is *she* hot?”

“I don’t know?” He didn’t really think about her like that, “I mean she’s alright-looking I guess? But she’s no Emilie Agreste. If he *was* going to move on though, which may I say he *isn’t,”* Those eyes in the creepy giant portrait of her his boss works in front of every day proclaims *that,* “then I mean he never leaves his house, and he hates most people so yeah, I guess it she probably would be the only person he'd date.”

Besides he felt that any other potential girlfriend of his boss would be rightly weirded out by the whole fact of her living in his house.

Chapter End Notes

[The article]

Chapter 5

A new alert comes up with a siren sound on his computer almost startling Claude out of his chair. Once over his shock he noticed the box on his screen saying just “Nathalie.”

“What the hell?” he muttered.

Nathalie *had* the ability to ring down if she needed something. She did it quite often. He had suspicions it was mostly boredom on her part. Or an inability to let go of her job since she kept offering what she clearly thought were useful comments about it.

Encouraging Adrien to spend more time with her had been one of the best thing he’d ever done. It’s a win for him, for Adrien and for Nathalie.

But unfortunately this is *not* that.

Belatedly it comes to him that he should go up and check on her because *whatever* the hell this is it’s apparently something to do with her and the notification looks like a warning not a reminder from the vibrant red edging.

Then he hears the slam of a door against the wall, and the sound of running feet against the marble stairs and it sounds like he’s been beaten to it by M.Agreste.

He follows anyway, running himself, now his employer’s haste has given confirmation of the urgency.

Claude finds his boss knelt over her on her bed. She looks-- not asleep the position against the headboard looks too awkward for that, but certainly not conscious and aware.

“Is she?”

M.Agreste’s hand are on her wrist and he slowly relaxes. “There’s a pulse.”

Claude stared. He’d known she wasn’t in a good place-she’d *collapsed* before, but he hadn’t thought she was in danger of *dying* in front of them. Hadn’t realised it was *that* vital to check for a pulse.

This job was supposed to be *temporary.*

She was supposed to get better.

Not for the first time here he felt utterly out of his depth. “Should I call an ambulance?”

There was a certain amount of déjà vu to the whole situation. Only now there was no obvious wound to explain it. Only the ongoing seeping loss on her health he’s stuck here watching.

Unlike the last time this time M.Argeste seemed to consider it and then said, “not yet. Help me get her in the recovery position.”

Part of Claude was still screaming *what is going on?* And another part of him was yelling *call 112* but he followed the instructions he was given as he was used to doing because his job was *supposed* to be helping his executive.

Suddenly Nathalie took a great gulp of air below them and both his and M.Agreste let go of her in guilt and surprise.

His boss called out, “Nathalie?”

Her eyes flickered and her hand reached for his and grabbed on as Claude watched.

She made a noise that wasn’t quite a word then gasped for air again.

“I’m here,” M.Agreste said, “what happened?”

“Coughed,” she croaked out, “couldn’t breathe.”

Claude flinched at the hoarseness in her voice, but nonetheless something in his chest seemed to unclench at her voice.

“Get her some water,” M.Agreste commanded him.

Nathalie made an awkward gesture with her hand.

“And a mug of hot water with honey and lemon,” his added, and then looking down at her went on, “actually add a dash of whiskey for that.”

Glad to have instructions to actually follow Claude turned on his heel and left.

He told himself that it wasn’t *fleeing* if he was just following the orders he’d been given by someone who actually understood the situation.

Carefully balancing the tray Claude paused in the doorway; where he could see the silhouette of the two of them. His boss was sat up against the headboard and she was resting back upon his chest. His arm was curled round her torso, whether to keep her in place or to offer comfort Claude wasn’t quite sure.

Suddenly all his convictions that there was nothing romantic going on between them started to look a little bit flimsy.

Technically the position they were in could be because it was good for her condition for her to be sat up and she was too weak to do it by herself or something along those lines.

Yet how they seemed relaxed into each other just didn’t quite look platonic.

He'd seen M.Agreste cradling her after her head injury but this looked like something else entirely.

"You're getting worse," M.Agreste said.

There was an odd tone to his voice as almost as if he felt guilty somehow but that didn't make sense. If he *was* responsible then surely he wanted to be and didn't have the morals to regret it, and if he *wasn't* responsible then he shouldn't have any reason to feel guilty.

"I'm not getting better, but we don't know that I'm getting worse." Mlle. Sancoeur disagreed.

"But today,"

"Happened *once,* it's not a regular occurrence."

"Nathalie," M.Agreste sighed, "we thought that before. I can't make the same mistake again."

Again? Claude thought. Was that why he'd let her keep working before now it turned out that he really *did* worry about her?

If she had seemed to be improving and then suddenly rapidly gone downhill then that did explain a *lot* of all the things he hadn't quite been able to reconcile.

"You're not," she disagreed, "it's fixed now. It can't harm me anymore."

Claude should have moved away. He knew that. But the lure of discovering what had happened to Mlle. Sancoeur was too strong. *What* was fixed? *How* had whatever it was harmed her?

"But what if it's already harmed you too much?"

Her hand went to his, "then we're only in the same place we were before."

His boss' head bent down so his chin was resting against the top of her head. "I can't lose you too."

Somehow his changed posture made his presence in her room seem less uncomfortable. Nathalie's room seemed *warm* and comfortable and many words that didn't seem to fit with Gabriel Agreste's formal exterior.

The man in front of her who looked honestly concerned about his, Claude was going to go with friend, made more sense there, than the stern boss he was used to.

Then suddenly that *too* slapped Claude right in the face.

Though it was true that it didn't *have* to mean anything. Just that he'd lost his wife and now he was losing his assistant explained it enough. It didn't have to mean it was the same thing exactly happening again.

It probably wasn't because M.Agreste didn't seem the type to actually have let same thing that had happened to his wife happen to Nathalie if he could avoid it. Whatever his faults not getting what he wanted wasn't one of them And anyway Emilie Agreste had disappeared. She hadn't died after a mysterious illness. The facts didn't line up.

"I'm right here, I'm not going anyway," Nathalie exhales, "anyway we shouldn't be talking about this. Claude will be back soon, and I don't think he'd be as understanding as I am."

"Probably not," M.Agreste agreed but though he took his head off hers he didn't otherwise move.

Claude carefully started inching back from the door before they could notice his presence. He probably *wasn't* anywhere near as understanding as Nathalie had been but it also wasn't as if he *didn't* have sympathy for the whole situation. He was just very very confused by it.

"You should be nicer to him," Nathalie said, and it felt a little incorrect that *she* was the one trying to defend *him.*

"He's not half the assistant you were."

He'd have loved to deny it but he knew it was the truth. That level of experience couldn't just be replaced liked that.

"I'm very good at what I do," she said sounding rather smug and honestly he couldn't even begrudge her because she *was,* "but even if he didn't lack all my years of experience working for you you *know* that how we've set up things now makes things difficult for him."

"I know," Gabriel sighed, "but you know why it has to be that way."

Claude would *love* to know why it had to be that way. Maybe. He was torn between wanting to know every secret this house had in the no doubt futile hope it would actually start making sense, and wanting desperately not to get any more involved than he already was.

Nathalie had clearly got involved and look where *she* had ended up.

This was just as job and he planned to *keep* it just a job. No late nights and weirdness for him. Nope.

Unfortunately, or maybe fortunately, he could no longer hear them from the current vantage point he'd retreated to.

Deciding he probably couldn't delay any longer without M.Agreste coming to see what he was going he decided to approach again slightly louder this time.

He knocked against the door with his elbow, as he pushed it fully open to get their attention. "I brought her water and toddy. Is there anything else you need?"

The two of them still hadn't moved out of position and his boss looked up at him and just said, "Thank you Claude. That will be all."

As if all of this was totally normal, and it was totally normal to hold your employee like that when she was on sick leave. Though given he'd already moved her into the house maybe he *did* think that this was normal for whatever the hell their relationship was.

"Claude?" Elodie sounded confused when she answered her phone. "I'm at work."

"I'm reconsidering your theory," he announced.

"You're *what?* Which one?"

"Not the murder one." He wasn't going to say anything more explicit than that in this house

"Wait," Elodie sounded gratifyingly incredulous, "What happened?"

So he told her.

She was silent for a moment then, "We need more evidence."

Getting more evidence was far easier for her to say than for him to do.

"Adrien?" Claude said, on their way to a new photoshoot to replace The Pigeon Catastrophe They Did Not Speak Of, "how long has Nathalie been working for your father?"

Adrien looked up as if he was surprised to be addressed, "all my life basically," then the boy frowned, "no that's not right, she wasn't hired until after I was born. But as far back as I can remember anyway. Why?"

"Oh," it didn't come off quite as airily as he'd hoped, "I was just wondering. They seem very close."

People did *not* usually move in with their bosses when they got ill but then it was admittedly quite possible that Adrien didn't really know that if Nathalie and her apparent inability to stop crossing professional boundaries was the main experience he had of those relationships actually worked.

He remembered abruptly that Adrien was technically an employee of the company too and suddenly wondered if he should be booking him on one of HR's anti-harassment courses because goodness knows he wasn't going to learn what appropriate professional relationships looked like from his father and Mlle. Sancoeur.

Bizzarely, and clearly completely oblivious to Claude's thoughts, Adrien seemed to light up at the comment on his father's relationship with his former assistant, "You've noticed?"

"It seems hard not to." He couldn't help but say much as he *deeply* wished things were otherwise.

"You would think so wouldn't you," Adrien muttered.

Claude looked at the boy, once again slightly confused as he seemed to be in a constant basis in this household, "Adrien?"

"Look Nathalie and Father. Like I said she's worked for him for ages, but that haven't always been *this* close. Since Mom disappeared I think they've got closer, but my father won't admit that."

Claude swallowed and it took every year of professional competence to be able to neutrally say, "I see."

"I mean, there's definitely something between them right? I'm not seeing things?"

"You sound like you want there to be," Claude dodged the question, because he didn't think Adrien would appreciate his honest answer that there was *something* between them but he had no idea what in hell it was and it quite possibly was not good because weirdly enough if he could understand the boy's body language at all he seemed to think this was a good thing.

Adrien tilted his head. "Why wouldn't I?"

"I could see it being quite awkward. What with the situation with your mother being so uncertain, and with Nathalie being your father's assistant."

There was a *hell* of a difference between doing the job Claude did now, and being Adrien's legal or not effective stepmother.

Adrien seemed to wilt in front of him. "I miss Mom." The boy said quietly.

"I'm sorry," Claude replied, wanting to punch himself in the face for bringing up his inexplicably missing mother to a grieving child.

"It's OK," Adrien said, looking far more put together and confident than Claude would in the same circumstances and *he* was an adult who would actually be expected to confront at least putting his mother in a nursing home sometime soon, "sometimes I *want* to talk about her. It's not like I can bring it up to Father. But she's gone, and she's probably not coming back. And I know that. So I wouldn't begrudge my father moving on. I want him to be happy. Maybe I'd feel weirder about it if it was someone else but it's *Nathalie.* She's basically part of my family already."

Claude had the uncanny feeling that *he* shouldn't be the person this was being said to. He also felt quite dizzy at the idea of someone doing his job being considered *family* by the boy, but as Adrien had said Nathalie had been here for *years.* It wasn't the same thing.

“That’s very sweet of you Adrien. I’m,” god, managing the expectations of an upset teenager was *so* out of his skill-set. “afraid that Nathalie might be too unwell for anything like that though.”

Adrien seemed to tense. Claude was weirdly reminded of a cat arching its spine and fluffing its fur despite the fact that wasn’t the boy’s posture at all and he sat upright in that seat, no doubt in imitation of his father.

Then Adrien said, “but she’s getting better right? Father told me she was going to be ok. Did he say something different to you?”

Claude felt like something was blocking his throat as images of her unconscious flashed through his mind.

“Your Father hasn’t said anything to me.” He told Adrien. “I assume Mlle. Sancoeur’s medical issues are confidential,” though he wasn’t starting to think Gabriel Agreste wouldn’t have any issues about ignoring that. “

“But your job placement is temporary right?” Adrien said, “So she *must* be going to get better.”

“Yes,” his job placement was definitely temporary at least. However when he’d been hired Nathalie Sancoeur had seemed to have been *hiding* the extent of her illness from her boss and *now* she was living in his house and letting him look after her so it was really all a very mixed picture. “I suppose so.”

Adrien had lost some of the tension in his body but now he was fidgeting in his seat. “Father really hasn’t told you *anything?*”

“Only instructions about getting her what she needs. Why?”

“No reason,” Adrien sighed, “it just reminds me of my mom sometimes.”

“Oh,” Claude said despite the gaping hole that had just opened up in his stomach. Perhaps M.Agreste *hadn’t* just been referring to the chance of them losing them both, and he desperately tried to cast his mind back to the company gossip before Emilie Agreste had disappeared.

There *had* been talk of her being ill he realised and sort of felt like it wanted to throw up.

But Adrien just hummed an acknowledgement without any further explanation and then they were at the photoshoot.

Claude hesitated as he passed his boss the files, “M.Agreste?”

“Yes?”

It was the least inviting yes that Claude had ever heard but he felt obligated to ask.

“If I’m not overstepping then, what illness exactly does Mlle. Sancoeur actually have?”

The man’s cold eyes met Claude’s, hard as steel, as he answered. “You *are* overstepping.”

“I’m sorry.”

M.Agreste seemed to somehow loom over him more than he did usually. “I’m surprised you thought to ask. I thought people in your profession were supposed to understand discretion. I’d have thought it was obvious Nathalie wouldn’t want the deals of her health splattered over the press.”

“I wasn’t going to talk to the tabloids sir.” Claude was insulted enough some of his fear left him, “I haven’t even told anyone she’s staying here,” except Elodie but she was his *girlfriend.* It’s not like he could keep secrets from her. “I just thought maybe if I had a better understanding of the situation then I could better anticipate her needs.”

For a second, for the first time ever, Claude thought he saw a resemblance to Adrien in the boy’s father as M.Agreste looked him over in apparent consideration.

Then the man made the faintest impression of a shake of his head, and his usual icy exterior re-established itself. “I’ll inform you if Nathalie has any needs that aren’t being fulfilled.”

It was a dismissal and Claude recognised it as one so he inclined his head in acceptance and turned to go.

Something made him pause at the threshold of the door though, and then M.Agreste spoke again. “Nathalie,”

Claude turned wondering if the man had called out the wrong name by force of habit.

Facing back into the Atelier he discovered his boss had his back to him. Hands firmly crossed behind him, and looking up and his wife’s portrait.

“I do worry about her,” M.Agreste said.

That’s obvious sir, Claude thought. Instead he said, “that’s understandable sir.”

In a second first he did almost feel sympathetic to the man in front of him. Not only was it clear he still worshipped his wife and hadn’t killed her he also seemed honestly shaken by Mlle. Sancoeur’s situation underneath his usual front.

“She has a tendency to downplay any problems” M.Agreste said, “it made her a good assistant but it’s less useful when it comes to the current situation.”

Uncertain but seeing the only chance he might get Claude ventured, “I did notice that she seemed to be trying to hide her condition from you while she was still working.”

That seemed the only explanation that made any type of sense for her reticent behaviour around their boss since she now seemed extraordinarily comfortable about living with the man and letting him manhandle her so it could hardly be that she disliked him, and didn't seem like she was frightened of him either.

Though that only made it seem odder that she'd tried to hide the situation from him. He'd thought that perhaps she was just one of those people who put too put of her self-worth into her work and didn't want to lose it but it still seemed like a bit of a stretch.

It certainly couldn't have been because she didn't want to lose seeing the Agrestes each day seeing as it had turned out that she wasn't losing that at *all.*

"Yes." The man said and the grip of his clasped hands seemed to tighten. "If she," he seemed to struggle, "admits anything of how she is to you I want you to ensure you tell me. I will of course keep this from Nathalie herself."

"Sir?" Claude couldn't not sound confused, "Wouldn't she be more likely to say something to you?"

Claude was extremely worried about the woman, and the two of them got along well enough, but he barely knew her.

He felt uncomfortable sitting down beside her on that bed while M.Agreste would plonk himself down there like it was his place.

So it seemed quite obvious that if she was going to confide in either of them it wouldn't be *him.*

"Just tell me if he does," M.Agreste says, and this time it definitely is a final dismissal.

"Nathalie," he asks, and she looks up from the email on the laptop he'd brought up to ask her about as an excuse for being here, "*Are* you doing alright?"

"Why wouldn't I be?" She asks, as if she's not currently confined to bedrest in her boss' house.

There seemed rather a *lot* of answers to that. Only some of them were even poloite.

With restraint he managed to say, ""M.Agreste seems worried,"

"He's always worried." She said. "He's going to fine. He just needs to concentrate on what he needs to do."

It didn't escape him that she'd said *he'd* be fine. Not that *she* would be.

“I am trying my best to help him with the company,” he offered as if that could be any real comfort. Not that it wouldn’t be easier if the man *didn’t* cloister himself away. Though she probably was already aware of that.

And indeed, “I know,” she said.

“I just can’t figure it,” he admitted to Elodie, “because the thing *is* that them having a relationship doesn’t even explain what the hell is going on in that house and between them.”

Chapter 6

“Ok, this is officially weird,” his little sister said, though not without some clear amusement, “you’re not trying to tell me I need to actually get a real job?”

He reached out for the bottle of wine on the coffee table and poured himself a glass, “Real jobs might be overrated.”

If it wasn’t for the guilt he’d feel at abandoning Mlle. Sancoeur and Adrien in that whole situation then Claude thought he might have quit already. They could *probably* just about survive on Elodie’s salary until the move to Marseille.

The Claude who had never worked directly for M.Agreste would have goggled at him in horror at that statement.

Claude didn’t feel very much like that Claude these days.

He certainly didn’t feel up to telling his sister she needed to stop trying to be an eternal student.

Léa looked between him and Élodie in confusion. “Am I missing something?”

Claude had generally avoided discussing the whole Elodie-thinks-my-boss-killed-his-wife-and-I’m-starting-to-wonder-if-he’s-killing-his-assistant-too-but-he-seems-to-regret-it situation much with his sister because she’s his *little sister* and much as he feels like he has some sort of responsibility to warn her about Men in general he figures that Gabriel Agreste is enough of an outlier it’s safe enough to shield her from whatever’s going on in his life.

Elodie looked up from her laptop on the kitchen counter, “oh, your brother hasn’t told you about the fairies then?”

“Wait, *what?*” Léa asked her, then turns her attention from his girlfriend to him, “are you suddenly taking after Grandma? Or are you trying to get her to leave all her money to you?”

“For a start, *what* money?” Unless Léa knows of some secret stash he doesn’t he’s fairly sure they’re not getting anything from that quarter. “And the fairies are *real.”*

Just like the possibility of M.Agreste and Mlle. Sancoeur being together, the fairies do not explain everything but they *do* explain some things. Like the cheese.

“And you have to placate them with cheese I know,” Elodie rolled her eyes and stood up.

“The cheese?” Léa asked, with a raised eyebrow and wide-eyes as if her features were trying to flee her face to somewhere that made more sense.

Claude could understand the impulse.

“Don’t ask.” Elodie said, snagging herself a wine glass from the cupboard. “Just don’t. Claude’s having to deal with working in a house with a hermit wife-killer, his mysteriously ill assistant, and the admittedly comparatively normal but *very* sheltered famous model son instead of a normal office with normal people and it’s driving him mad and now he believes in fairies.”

Léa made a reassuringly confused noise.

“Look I *saw* one of them hovering over M.Agreste’s shoulder.” He defended himself.

“OK, then,” Elodie replied coming over to them, “what did it look like?”

“Purple!” he retorted, “it had purple, sort-of butterfly wings and a big head and,” he lost his confidence a little, “OK, I only got a glance at it before it disappeared but it was definitely real.”

His sister still looked as if she was staring at some modern abstract artwork that made no sense, apart from possibly looking obscene, and she had no idea what to say about it which could sound knowledgeable or polite..

She swallowed, “are you alright? I mean, are you *safe?*”

“It’ll be alright,” Elodie reassured her, and call it soppy of him but his heart did a funny flippy thing in his chest whenever his girlfriend took it upon herself to comfort his sister, “it is a really weird situation but it’s an understandable coping mechanism. Your brother will be fine once this job is done with and we’ve both moved to Marseille.”

“No,” Léa shook her head the same way she had when she was a child and their father had claimed it was impossible to keep a horse healthily in Paris and she’d told him that he’d totally missed her point, “I mean is Claude *safe?* If he’s working for a murderer?”

“He’s not a murderer.” Claude repeated for the, he didn’t even know how many times it had been now, “like, I am *deeply* concerned about Mlle.Sancoeur but he does actually seem to care about her, *and* he’s clearly torn to pieces about whatever the hell happened with his wife.”

“I don’t understand why this is less convincing to you than the fairies,” Elodie said.

“*Because*, yes, I could totally believe that his wife disappeared when she got super ill because he hid her hooked up to a billion life support machines in the attic instead of letting her go to a hospital which would probably decide it was best to let her go and that he plans to do the same with Nathalie but I don’t think he’s deliberately killing them.”

Léa blinked, “I am not reassured.”

Elodie poured herself a glass of wine and topped up Léa’s glass before sitting down beside him. “Even if he *did* kill his wife and *is* killing his former assistants then Claude doesn’t fit the pattern of his victims.”

“Not-victims.” He corrected her.

“Unless he’s secretly cheating on me with his boss,” Elodie added, and he just *knew* she had a smirk on her face.

Claude took another gulp of wine, “please don’t make me want to throw up. *No.* If I had to date a guy then *he’d* be so far down the list he’d be in Antarctica. Whatever you see in him I don’t get it.”

It was horrendous enough imaging *Nathalie* will him. Scratch that. It was bad enough imaging M.Agreste’s actual wife with him. Imaging himself, *urgh,* it was made him want to scrounge out his own eyeballs.

Elodie gave Léa and unimpressed look. “Claude can’t understand why any woman would be interested in a tragically widowed tall rich guy with an adorable son who’s crying out for a mother.”

“You make him sound like he’s five. He’s a teenager.” A teenager with possibly terrible romantic taste given that he’d since verified that crazy-swimming-pool-girl *was* actually in his class. Claude lived in hope together everyday that Adrien would get back together with Kagami Tsurugi and *only* her and not with the obsessed hanger-on or with both of them at the same time in the way he’d kind of looked like he wanted to back at the swimming pool.

Claude didn’t *not* get it. He’d been a teenage boy once too. Even a teenage boy with girls he maybe liked at a swimming pool. He didn’t remember it being quite this messy though. Then again he hadn’t been a famous model.

And he hadn’t had to deal with akuma attacks.

That probably didn’t help given half of them seemed to be teenagers dealing with relationship issues, and nearly all of them seemed to happen *way* too close to Adrien for Claude’s liking.

Léa bit her lip. “But Claude’s ok?”

Claude was *not* ok but, “I’m not going to be murdered if that’s what you’re asking.”

“OK,” Léa said, “so you’re not going to be murdered but you are working in somewhere which sounds like it should be the settings of one of the books I’m reading for my dissertation *so,*”

“What’s your dissertation again?”

“The effects of the Terror on German and English Gothic Literature. It’s really interesting looking at how they reacted to it in totally different ways to how we did here considering you know, it didn’t actually happen to them.”

“Right,” Claude said faintly.

“I mean, it’d work better if it was Adrienne Agreste or you were Claudine but it’s pretty in line.”

“Oh my god,” Elodie said, “Adrien Agreste, Gothic Novel Heroine.”

“Oh god,” Claude said, “please no one ever say that to my boss. He would probably commission some sort of photoshoot based on it and I am *not* falling to my death off the turret of some crumbling chateau.”

Léa’s eyebrow popped up again, “why would you, oh.”

“Oh?”

“It’s the height thing isn’t it?” Léa said, with a slightly condescending twist to her lips.

Claude turned to glare at Elodie who had clearly mouthed something to his sister. “Lots of people are scared of heights. But yes.”

“I mean it’s kind of reassuring that at least you don’t think your boss is deliberately sending you to your death but,” she stopped, “*wait,* you’re Jonathan!”

It was his turn to be thrown by the conversation. “I’m what now?”

“From Dracula. I mean it’s kind of post my period but I’m reading it at the moment and it’s an unusual one for having a *guy* thrown into the weird as all out castle you know?”

“Uh, and how does that end for him?”

“Fine, I mean Dracula follows him back to England, and creeps on his ride-or-die fiancée and *wow,* pop-cultural reactions did not prepare me for how non-consensual everything between Dracula and Mina is and now my skin crawls when anything pairs them romantically, and I mean yeah their friend dies but he’s mostly fine.”

“Mostly fine?”

“I mean he was lucky to get back to England alive and not get killed by the vampire brides but he did so yeah?”

“That is not reassuring to me.” Claude could not imagine anything worse than the Agrestes following him to Marseille.

“Honestly though it is a *really* weird book to read.”

That sounded like a safer topic of conversation. “How so?”

“So part of it is that you have this idea of it in your head and then it is *not* that at all. Like, there’s a cowboy? But also its kind of hilarious because this girl is pale and exhausted and dying and she’s getting worse every night and it seems to be due to blood loss but she’s not bleeding out or anything. Then the one guy who’s in the know tells them to hang garlic, blossoms by the way *not* bulbs, to protect her and there’s a freaky bat and the reader isn’t supposed to know what it might be?”

The hairs on the back on his neck stand up on end, “wait, what were those symptoms again?”

His mind started to suddenly try and work out when was the last time his boss had left the house. Which-

Ah. Nathalie's hospital trip.

But it *had* been dark then.

And before that, he wasn't sure. True he *had* since Mme.Agreste's disappearance but,

"No." Elodie interrupted his train of thought, "the fairies are one thing. You can*not* decide that your boss is a vampire,"

"But,"

"No, maybe he's into some weird blood-drinking thing, he's rich enough to be into something like that, and maybe he killed his wife in an unfortunate accident but,"

"Wait," Léa asked, "his boss is into some weird blood-drinking thing?"

"No," Elodie thankfully answered for him, "his boss is keeping a woman upstairs in his house, whom he may or may not be romantically entangled with, and who is mysteriously ill from some unexplained illness that per Claude he seems to feel responsible for."

Claude winced slightly at the description, "I feel like I should clarify that she was his assistant,"

Léa frowned, "the one you're replacing?"

"Yes, she's worked for him for *years,* and is essentially the closest person to him after his wife. His son basically views her as family. She's not just some random woman off the street."

"I guess that kind of make sense." Léa said but she looked much like Claude thought he must have when he'd gone back to work the day after her accident and he'd found Nathalie Sancoeur there.

"It makes more sense if they're secretly together." Elodie maintained. "No, Claude don't give me that look. You admitted it was a possibility the other day."

He buried his face in his hands at the memory and at the moments he'd seen *since,* "I know."

The couch rustled as she clearly leaned in to hear more, "wait, has something else happened?"

"He carried her," he mumbled.

"What?" Elodei and Léa chorused.

Then his sister said, "Claude we can't hear you."

He looked up at that, “She and Adrien were talking in his room and his father and I went up to get him because it was time for him to perform his piano pieces to his father.”

“Perform,” Léa said, “Not *practise?* What sort of 19th century nonsense way is your employer raising his child?”

“19th Century nonsense seems about right. Very seen and not heard you know? I think it’s a money thing. Posh people aren’t like the rest of us.”

Claude halfway wondered if he could sign his boss up for a parenting seminar or possibly therapy without him realising what it was.

“But isn’t he self-made? Like he didn’t come from poverty or anything but I didn’t think he came from money either?”

“I think he’d take any excuse to avoid people,” apart from apparently Nathalie Sancoeur, whom he’d moved into his house.

Elodie shrugged, “*Emilie* Agreste *was* old-money though none of the things I’ve read about her disappearance make it clear whether or not she was in on the whole raising the boy like that thing.”

“She must have been,” Claude said, “she had that man twisted around her little finger from what I heard and once again,”

“Putting someone on a pedestal doesn’t mean you actually listen to them,” Elodie disagreed before he could bring up the painting and the stature. “It’s a hell of a lot more complicated than that.”

“Maybe,” he said, since after all *nothing* seemed to not be complicated in that house.

“Anyway,” Elodie smiled, though he didn’t think it looked half as encouraging as she surely meant it. It looked rather more as it she was anticipating a particularly well-cooked meal, “continue with your story.”

“So,” he started, “Adrien makes a remark about how he wishes *she* could see how he’d improved from the last time she saw him play and maybe I could record it for her, and she makes all these encouraging noises at the idea but before she can ask me to, M.Agreste demands the tablet.”

“To do it himself?”

Claude shook his head, he *wished* that was the case, “as far as I can tell to check on her health, because then he announces he thinks she can manage the trip to the other room.”

The frown on Léa’s face hadn’t shifted, “why would the *tablet* tell him that?”

“She’s hooked up to this machine, it feeds information to it,”

“Uh,” Léa’s jaw dropped open.

“Yeah don’t ask.”

Something flashed in her eyes, and Claude had a disturbing premonition of her starting off on one of her righteous fits, “shouldn’t she be in a hospital then?”

“You would think so,” Elodie said as she put her glass down with a little too much force.

“She’s where she wants to be,” Claude said tiredly, “that much I actually am certain of. It’s just, you know, the *rest* of it that I’m completely lost about.”

“Apparently,” Elodie said, “I just *really* worry about her judgement.”

“So do we all.” He agreed, “because then M.Agreste handed me back the tablet,” thrust it back into his hands really, “told Adrien to move, and *literally picked her up* and carried her to the other room.”

“What?” Léa said.

“He picked her up.”

“Yeah no I got *that.* I meant *how?*”

“Bridal style.”

Elodie gasped.

Léa held up her hand, “OK so, one what the actual hell, and *yeah,* I get why Elodie thinks they’re together but also, he’s strong enough to do that?”

“Apparently.”

“Does he have like a secret gym in that house or something?”

“I’m not aware of one, but I would not be surprised.”

Elodie tilted her head in confusion, “don’t you know all the rooms in that house?”

“No. Why *would* I? And also would *you* go opening closed doors in that house?”

Claude did not even want to *know* what else there might be there. At this point he didn’t think he’d be surprised by anything. Hawk Moth himself could be in one of the guest bedrooms and he thought at this stage he’d probably just blink and ask the supervillain if the accommodation was to his satisfaction.

And honestly he hadn’t been joking earlier-if he found Emilie Agreste in the same set-up as Nathalie Sancoeur but *worse* he honestly wouldn’t be surprised.

Conflicted perhaps about what he was expected to do in the situation but not surprised.

“I mean I probably would but fair point.” Elodie said.

Léa seemed to be making shapes in the air in with her hands, “I’m still confused about the mechanics of this, like how could he even,”

“Oh,” Claude realised, “she helped. Tugged the duvet off the bed and reached her arms up around his neck and all.”

“Oh ok,” Léa nodding, “that makes more sense,” though it didn’t look like it made much sense to her at all.

“*That* suggests he’s done it before,” Elodie said, “which yikes.”

“I mean I guess if the time she went to hospital wasn’t the first time she fainted then he couldn’t just leave her on the floor?”

There was a considering glint in Elodie’s eye, “how did the kid react?”

“What?”

“*Adrien.* Did it look like *he’d* seen it before?”

“Hmm,” Claude cast his mind back, “no, he *did* look shocked for a moment. But not surprised. Like he didn’t expect it but it *did* make sense to him?”

“Interesting.”

“Please remember the boy actually *wants* there to be something between her and his father. I worry everyday about what growing up in that environment is doing to his ideas about romantic relationships.”

“You don’t,” Léa almost laughed.

“I *do,*” Claude declared, “I’ve signed him up for a course on appropriate workplace relationships. I think it will be good for him.”

Someone had to ensure the boy had some idea how these sort of things worked and it clearly wasn’t going to be Adrien’s father.

“It *is* kind of unusual though,” Elodie mused, “clearly *Adrien* doesn’t blame them for his mother’s disappearance.”

“He wouldn’t,” Claude said, “he’s not that type of kid. Honestly I think he’s probably too forgiving for his own good. Seriously though I think its abandonment issues coming through. He worries about losing Nathalie like he lost his mother and clearly if Nathalie’s in a relationship with his father then she won’t leave his family.”

“That didn’t stop his mother,” Elodie pointed out.

Silence fell between the three of them at the abrupt reminder that to one teenage boy Emilie Agreste wasn’t a mysterious unsolved case but an actual person whom he’d deeply loved and whose absence had torn his family apart.

“Poor kid,” Léa said, “I hope for his sake she gets better. *And* for hers because this whole scenario sounds dubious as anything.”

“Oh we all agree with that.” Elodie said.

“He does care for them you know?” Claude said, “it’s just,”

“The rest of it,” Elodie agreed.

Claude found himself playing with a thread that was coming loose on his jeans, “You know, if he *was* a vampire then that would explain him being strong enough to carry her.”

“*Or,”* Elodie said, “maybe he goes to the gym so he was able to carry his dead wife’s body.”

“We don’t know she’s dead.”

“Anyway,” Léa said, “apart from the fact that vampires aren’t real, and I can’t believe I have to tell you that I’m pretty sure he’s been out in daylight without any issue? Not that’s a thing in all vampire stories, as I’ve learned now, but he doesn’t seem to have an issue travelling over water either. I know he’s a hermit but didn’t he go out in public to open a store in Shanghai a while back?”

“Oh yeah,” Claude relaxed and said with a smile, “he *did.”*

“*And,”* Elodie said, “didn’t she refer to a *thing* that hurt her not a person.”

The reminder of the mysterious danger was rather less comforting and the smile fell off his face, “yeah she did.”

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

um, trigger warning for non-existent but concerns about sexual abuse of a minor?

Usually M.Agreste tended to be already cloistered away in his office before Claude arrived. Erratic he might be and Claude couldn't help but think the man could probably have a shorter workday if he was more productive *during* it instead of getting distracted by whatever other than Nathalie he got distracted by but it couldn't be denied that he was dedicated to giving his time over to it.

So obviously *today* was the day he wasn't. The multi-coloured bouquet of flowers which had already worsened his mood by making him sneeze threatened to fall out of his suddenly sweating hands.

"I don't recall asking you to order flowers for the house," M.Agreste said softly but with a rather dangerous bite to it. "Or are they samples for the next show?"

He was forced to look up even more than usual at his boss as the man was standing on the first flight of stairs looming over him. Either he had apparently chosen to wait for him to arrive there or he was equally awkwardly waiting for Adrien, or he had some inexplicable fondness for standing on that step.

Unfortunately being the man he was the last wasn't actually impossible.

"Um," Claude swallowed and regretted it a moment later because he was *convinced* he'd just inhaled pollen again. "They're ah, for Nathalie."

M.Agreste expression didn't change, nor did he move, and yet Claude could swear something in his eyes seemed to have changed. "I see."

He didn't move, and technically Claude *would* fit past him on the stairs to bring them up to Nathalie but it would be awkward. Even more awkward than the situation already was.

"She's not allergic or anything?" He suddenly panicked at the implacable barrier being presented to him, "I didn't really think,"

"No," M.Agreste said, looking rather constipated, "she's not allergic. Though I'm not sure she really has the health for this sort of thing right now."

"Flowers?" Claude asked in confusion, "Aren't they a pretty standard get well soon thing? My girlfriend,"

M.Agreste's frown minutely eased, "You have a girlfriend?"

There was a disturbing sense of déjà vu to the man asking the same question his son had and perhaps *that* was why he almost thought that he could hear some of the same expression behind it despite the fact the idea sounded stupid when Adrien was such an open expressive child and his father was such a closed off glacial man.

"Uh yeah. I guess you wouldn't know?" Though Claude was pretty sure he'd been thoroughly background checked in a way that was probably slightly illegal before getting the job that didn't mean Nathalie would share it all with M.Agreste if she didn't deem it necessary. And she hadn't seemed to deem *a lot* necessary based on the way she'd acted before she'd been forced to bedrest. "But yeah Elodie, that's my girlfriend, thought it was rubbish of me not to get her anything after her injury but given Mlle. Sancoeur's still ill she thought these might be nice. Brighten up her room or something."

He awkwardly held the flowers out.

"It's very kind of her to think of Nathalie," M.Agreste said and finally walked down the stairs. "You must thank her for me."

"It's nothing, we just." Claude shut his mouth at the memory of how his boss had reacted the last time he'd asked about Nathalie's life.

"Just what?"

"It just seemed a pity no one else had got her anything."

"I'm aware I don't do enough for Nathalie."

"What? No I didn't mean *you* I mean you've set her up in your house, you're doing a lot for her," and *you're only supposed to be her boss* he thought, "just that you'd think some friends and family would show up."

"The flowers are well-meaning," he reached out and took them from Claude, "and I'll ensure she gets them. But Nathalie prefers to keep her private life private. I'd advise not asking her about it."

This time it was that first day and Nathalie herself that Claude was reminded of.

"M.Agreste prefers formality."

That was true from everything Claude had heard and seen but then the woman saying it had been the same woman Claude had since seen M.Agreste sit down next to on her bed and carry around.

He wondered if *his* description of her was as much a façade as *her* description of him had been.

"You can get to work." M.Agreste dismissed him.

“Nino!” Adrien’s voice came muffled through the door. “Stop laughing! I’m being serious.”

Claude knocked at the door and the boy’s conversation dropped off.

“Sorry,” he heard Adrien make his excuses as he opened the door.

Claude did feel a little bad about it but, “I just wanted to remind you that we have to leave for your replacement photoshoot in half an hour.”

Adrien seems to stand to attention, “Do I need to change or shower or anything?”

He shook his head, “Your clothes will be waiting for us there along with a make-up artist.”

“OK,” Adrien said, “I’ll be ready. Hopefully there won’t be an akuma this time!”

Claude shuddered at the reminder of the pigeon fiasco. Every time he tried to forget it it just came back. It was hardly Adrien’s fault but still, “I hope not. Fingers crossed today goes smoothly.”

He really really did hopes so. Not that he had much hope for the entire situation. A photoshoot by candlelight just seemed doomed to failure however romantic it might seem.

And it includes yet another teenage model and frankly Adrien’s the only one Claude trusts to have any sort of sense. The boy might have his quirks and only terrible role models at home and a worrying tendency to disappear but he is a professional at least.

He hasn’t quite got the door shut when he hears, “that’s the guy?”

The voice echoes out of a tinny microphone and Adrien must have left the video call going. He should probably say something to the boy about that. After all he’s probably too used to having his privacy infringed to realise other people aren’t comfortable with it..

“Yeah, he’s pretty ok,” he says, “even if I wish Nathalie would just get better.”

“I’ll give you that *she* apparently knows you better than to think you needed to go on an anti-sexual harassment course.”

Claude sighs as he shut the door. It had been on workplace relationships *generally.* And it had been *mostly* about making sure Adrien didn’t think his father and Nathalie’s situation was normal. And anyway it’s good for Adrien to know how to deal with both sides of the equation and—

Well he feels pretty vindicated on thinking Adrien needed to know how to deal with being harassed.

“You know,” the teenage female model said, “I bet your father would love it with we dated. It would be such good publicity. He’d have to let us out more for social media photos for the brand you know.”

Adrien’s smile was becoming more and more fixed, “I’m not really interested in dating at the moment Lila. I need to deal with school, and look, I realise you want friends and I’m flattered you’d chose me but when I want to date someone I want it to be because I love them.”

The girl wasn’t quite good enough to hide her irritation, but managed a smile of her own, “we wouldn’t have to *actually* date. Just pretend to.”

Even from a distance Claude thought his ‘what the actual hell’ face was probably less good than Adrien’s.

And indeed Adrien only looked mildly confused when he said, “Why would I do that?”

“Be*cause,”* she said with a flick of her hair, *“*then your father would let you out of the house more, and we could hang out with the rest of the class.”

Claude’s heart sank at the idea that Adrien knew this girl outside work. At this point he was thinking that even crazy-swimming-pool-hanger-on-girl might have been an improvement. She was pretty short but she might have had a cute enough face for editorial and at least she wasn’t actually trying to get Adrien to date her.

At least Adrien had the sense to draw back in suspicion. “Why would *you* want to do that?”

“You’re *Adrien Agreste.* If you like me then other people would think I’m worth liking.”

“Lila, I’ve told you. You don’t have to *lie* to make people like you. Just be nice to them.”

The girl laughed, “I think you have had a very different life to me Adrien.”

“Alright,” Claude said to the photographer who’d theoretically been showing him the shots on his camera but in fact they’d both been listening to the kids, “I’m going to go break that up.”

Enough was enough. Adrien was *working.* He shouldn’t have to deal with this whatever damage the girl already had. He was starting to think maybe he needed to send an entire school year off to therapy. Maybe he could convince his employer it would have a good return on investment as a charitable expense.

They’d get tax relief *and* they’d have way less akumas for at least a few months before the year below them grew up enough for their own set of partially romantic insecurities.

“I don’t suppose you could call the whole thing off and re-schedule with another model?” The photographer said, without *quite* begging him but coming pretty close.

Claude looked at him in surprise. “Do you think *I* have that sort of pull with M.Agreste?”

The man shrugged, “I hoped Mlle. Sancoeur did after the last debacle with this one, but apparently not.” He shook his head, “How can this girl have zero chemistry on camera with him Adrien she’s draping herself over him off camera.”

Claude snorted at the mess in front of them. “Would you say he has chemistry with her off camera?”

Adrien certainly didn’t seem interested in the slightest and the boy could actually act.

“Touché.” The photographer acknowledged.

Claude sighed and called his charge, “Adrien. Can you come here?”

The boy looked far too relieved to be able to be out of the girls claws, and nearly ran over to them.

Adrien almost bounced on the balls. “Did you have feedback?”

“I think we’re going to try a few shots of just you,” Claude said, and got a thankful nod from the photographer. Hopefully they could salvage *something* from this shoot. “But Adrien.”

“Yes?”

“Are you OK?”

Adrien looked at him, far too confused for a boy that had just been rescued from an awkward situation, “I’m fine.”

Claude hesitated, because if Adrien *was* fine then maybe this was just teenage drama, but still “She seemed a little pushy.”

“That’s just Lila.” Adrien said with a shrug. “I can handle it.”

“That’s not something you should be expected to do. Do you remember your course?”

“I’m not,” Adrien shut his mouth suddenly after a look of pure offense as realisation passed through his eyes.. “*Wait.* You’re saying *she’s* the one crossing boundaries?”

“Yes.” Claude agreed. “That’s exactly what I’m saying.”

Adrien wrinkled his nose. “I hadn’t really thought about it like that. I mean I know her from school so it’s not as if we just work together but yeah if it’s coming off that way to other people too then I can talk to her.”

Claude was slightly thrown by Adrien’s confidence. “You can?”

The boy drew himself up to his full, growing if not yet impressive, height. “We have an understanding.”

It would have been more convincing coming from the boy’s father but still, “you do?”

Adrien hand went to the back of his neck awkwardly, “Lila’s a little overeager to establish herself in Paris. She travels around a lot for her mother’s work you know? She’s lonely. I get that. But I’m not that used to all that social stuff either so maybe I’m missing things when she goes too far?”

“Yes.” Claude said dully. “Yes, you’re definitely missing things.”

This poor boy had no idea what normal even looked like if he thought *that* was normal. Then again he apparently thought his father and Nathalie were normal.

“Huh,” Adrien said.

Despite his talk with Adrien Claude still felt the need to say something to the girl while they were watching Adrien posing.

“Oh,” she said looking up at him, “Hi. He’s so good at it isn’t he?”

She paired it with a more convincing smile. She’d was going to be pretty good at the whole feminine manipulation thing once she’d grown up but right now Claude thought she reminded him more of kitten sharpening it’s claws than a cat extending them out in comparison to half the women he had to interact with on a daily basis in the fashion industry.

“He is.” He said. “And he’s better when he’s not distracted.”

Lila blinked up at him, “*distracted?* Are you, are you saying I’m distracting to him? We’re *friends.* I’m sorry if you don’t think we’re professional enough but,”

His sympathly didn’t quite extend to not-quite-convincing faux shows of acquiescence. “*You’re* not.”

Clearly affronted the girl’s eyes narrowed. “I’m sorry?”

“Your behaviour with Adrien *is* inappropriate. It needs to stop.”

Her mouth fell apart as her eyes widened and she gasped, “I’m just trying,”

“I know what you’re trying. But he’s not interested.” He said, and then because he was somewhat sympathetic to the girl given that the rest of them that weren’t born rich had to work at it and she was clearly trying but, “And frankly you’re not good enough to get away with it.”

Her attempt at pure confusion was actually rather decent. “What?”

“Adrien’s naïve and he’s only doing this because of his dad. *You’re* not and I think *you* actually have ambition.”

She continued with that clearly constructed to be cute frown. “Isn’t that a good thing?”

Claude winced. “It can be,” and he didn’t even begrudge her that, “but if you keep trying to take shortcuts like that it’ll blow up in your face. Frankly, though it’s not been in much evidence today. I think you have a chance of making something of yourself but not if I have to report back to Adrien’s father that we have to blacklist you.”

This time, the girl smirked. “Oh, Adrien’s father won’t blacklist me.”

Claude suddenly felt a little off course. “I’m sorry.”

“Don’t you know?” She twirled her hair around her finger, “I’m his new muse. He understands me. He’s going to make me the face of his brand.”

His stomach turned over in horror and suddenly his impression of the young teenager in front of him playing with forces she didn’t quite grasp yet felt accurate in a far more concerning way.

He tried to get his voice steady. “You’ve met M.Agreste?”

The girl smiled, and there was an actual delight in her eyes, that made his sudden nausea worsen, “Of course I have. You see, he was upset I’d snuck in to help Adrien with his homework so I went an apologised and once he actually met me he understood I was such an asset to the brand.”

Claude had never before actually *wanted* Mlle. Sancoeur and M.Agreste to be in a relationship before. Wanted to be sure he actually cared about the women, *yes,* though he was pretty sure he did at this point. Wanted their relationship something normal, certainly. But he’d never actually wanted them to be together romantically. For her sake as much anything.

Right now he wanted M.Agreste to be in love with his former assistant with every fibre of his being.

Because it he *was* then at least Claude had some hope that it was unlikely he was having an inappropriate reaction to an *actual child* the literal same age as his son.

“I see,” he tried to gulp down his burning building up in his throat, “and how exactly do you do that?”

“I think he just recognised my natural talent,” the girl said and his heart sank as she added, “of course he’s not the first. Back in Italy I had any number of fashion houses interested in me you know. I had to tell Donatella,”

“Yes right,” he cut the girl off, “but I need you to know there are people you can talk to?”

“Talk to?” Lila asked with a frown, “like the press? The *real* press? Not jumped up fakes like the Ladyblogger?”

“Oh my god,” Claude said, “you’re the one that claimed to be Ladybug’s friend.”

“I can neither confirm or deny that,” Lila said. “Given you know, Hawk Moth.”

“Yes I understand, but Lila?”

“Yes?”

“If anyone tries to make you do anything you don’t want to do then you can tell me. OK? Or anyone else here? You don’t just have to obey M.Agreste because he’s important. If anything’s wrong I can take you to the police station?”

Just because he worked for the man and because he was despite his own best effects almost becoming sympathetic to him that didn’t mean he wasn’t going to make sure this girl didn’t get whatever help and support she needed.

Tears started to build up in Lila’s eyes, and his hands awkwardly clenched at his sides. In the circumstances it didn’t seem right to touch her.

“No one can help being akumatised,” Lila said.

“I know,” Claude answered totally thrown by the twist in the conversation.

“It’s not my *fault* it happened more than once. It’s not just me. It’s that Pigeon guy, and one of the other girls in my glass has been akumatised way more than I have. I don’t know anything about Hawk Moth to tell the police. Why would you be so cruel just because you don’t like that I’m friends with Adrien?”

“No one blaming you for being akumatised,” Claude said feeling relief seep through him at her response even as he now had a new reason to treat her with kid gloves, “That’s Hawk Moth’s fault not yours.”

“Thank you,” the girl said weepily. “It’s so nice to meet someone who understands.”

He stared at his phone. It *seemed* a neutral enough comment.

“Is it true M.Agreste himself hired Lila?”

Nathalie’s answer came back almost immediately. “Unfortunately yes. Why? Is she being a problem on set again?”

“Yes.”

“I can try talking to him.”

“does he actually think she’s good?”

This time there was a long gap before she responded.

He tried not to constantly check his phone for a notification but eventually he got back.

“I think she reminds him of Emilie.”

Claude promptly felt sick again.

Claude stared at the Atelier door then turned around, and headed into his own office, before ringing through on the tablet.

Sometimes discretion was the better part of valour. Especially with how awkward and fraught the topic was.

M.Agreste picked up the call, “yes?”

He didn’t give any further sort of greeting. Unfortunately Claude was used to that at this point.

“We’re back from the photoshoot.” Claude announced.

“I see.” His boss said, “did it go well?”

“Adrien put on an exemplary performance.”

The boy’s father nodded, “as always.”

“His partner for a shoot was rather less so.”

M.Agreste scowled, “who was the female model? I don’t have time for failures.”

For once that actually felt like a reassurance rather than a future problem and Claude tried to keep his face as blank as possible as he said. “Lila Rossi.”

“Ah.” M.Agreste said. “That’s unfortunate.”

This was the moment. He knew it. And he didn’t *want* to bring it up but if he was any sort of decent human being he knew he had to, and he did like to think of himself as a fairly decent person.

Uneasy as anything he ventured. “Sir?”

“Yes?”

“Is there a *reason* why we can’t just dismiss Mlle.Rossi?”

The man dismissed him. “She’s Adrien’s friend.”

“It didn’t look like that today.” M.Agreste didn’t answer him immediately so he added, “her advances appeared to make him uncomfortable.”

His boss stared at him through the tablet screen“Advances?”

“She kept suggesting they should date. Apparently you’d approve.”

Once again the man scowled, “That’s not our,”

He didn’t continue after his sudden stop and it took every bit of Claude’s professionalism not to show the disgust on his face, “you’re what?”

M.Agreste didn’t answer his question. “She doesn’t have to work with Adrien. There’s lots of other work out there isn’t there?”

Claude tried to contain his sigh. “She’s too young for the catwalk. But maybe in a year or so?”

“Well find her something.” M.Agreste said. “And maybe schedule me a call with her.”

He tried his best but some of his incredulity leaked through in his. “*You?*”

“Yes.”

“I just,” Claude’s fingernails bit into his legs through his trousers under the table. “don’t think that would be very appropriate sir.”

His boss looked at him as if he was an ant he wanted to squish. “I’m sorry?”

“You’re not in charge of hiring or staffing. People might find it rather odd you meeting with her by yourself. Especially given her age.” Claude just about managed.

“Her age?”

He’d gone far enough by this point. “She is a teenager sir.”

“Yes, that’s why she works with Adrien.”

Either the man truly was oblivious or Gabriel Agreste was a truly exemplary actor. For once Claude was glad for all the weirdness in the house because the very fact he’d been exposed to it suggested the former not the latter.

“She referred to herself as your muse sir.”

“She what?” M.Agreste barked, seeming fully offended, “*Emilie’s* my muse. Or perhaps Adrien. That’s very presumptuous of the girl to claim. I definitely need to talk to her.”

“Perhaps someone in the legal department should handle that conversation. It certainly seems like something worth heading off.”

“Yes. She seems to have quite forgotten her place.”

Reassuring as that response almost was, “that wasn’t my major concern sir.”

“What was your concern?”

Uneasily he volunteered. “It rather seemed like a possible PR issue.”

His boss didn’t quite seem to get the point. “What?”

“She’s Adrien’s age sir.”

“So?”

“So. I think most people would be rather uncomfortable with an actual child replacing your late wife as your muse.”

Despite the man’s near permanent tan, which honestly Claude had questions about, M,Agreste went pale as the implication finally hit him.

“You think? *Lila?* She’s, I might exploit teenagers but I don’t exploit them *that* way. God. If anything she’d be like the *daughter* I could have had not,” he seemed to physically recoil over then screen, “anything else.”

Claude recalled Emilie Agreste’s laughing green eyes. But also fair skin and blonde hair that didn’t quite fit. And then he looked at his employer with his olive skin. And he remembered Nathalie Sancoeur’s dark hair.

And he decided it was better not to comment on it.

“That’s all well and good sir,” he said, “but should I make the appointment with legal or HR?”

“Please do.” M.Agreste said.

End Notes

So this was actually the first ML fic I ever wrote. I never got past the first two chapters but thought it might be worth posting the first two and seeing if the comments inspired me like they did for Unwanted Entanglements.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!